

BRUNO DE PÁDUA SANTOS SALGADO

Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT)

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NARRATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF TEXTUAL INVARIANCE (ANIT)
A Structural Model of Narrative Reorganization with Full Preservation of Textual
Materiality

Technical document of theoretical formulation that presents and formalizes the model entitled Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT), originally developed and applied by the author in 2025.

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2025

I declare that the model entitled Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT) was originally developed, structured, and applied by Bruno de Pádua Santos Salgado, Brazil, 2025.

The model is characterized by the complete structural reorganization of a narrative text without any lexical, syntactic, punctuation, or material alteration.

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ABSTRACT

This study proposes the formalization of a structural model entitled Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT), characterized by the complete reorganization of a literary work without any alteration to its textual materiality. The study demonstrates that modifying the structural order of narrative segments may generate distinct interpretive experiences while fully preserving each original textual unit. The central hypothesis maintains that textual invariance is independent of the formal sequence applied, making it possible to alter structural architecture without compromising the lexical, syntactic, or punctuation integrity of the work.

For empirical verification, two complete versions of the same previously published short story are presented, organized in distinct sequences yet composed of exactly the same textual units. The formal analysis includes descriptive logical modeling, objective criteria of verifiability, and full demonstration in the annexes. It is concluded that ANIT constitutes a verifiable structural model in which order functions as an ontological operator capable of producing distinct narrative realities without any rewriting, suppression, insertion, or modification of content.

Keywords: narrative architecture; textual invariance; narrative permutation; narrative ontology; textual verification; structural narrative theory.

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1. Introduction

A. Traditionally, the creation of new narrative works has been associated with textual modification, whether through rewriting, suppression, insertion, or adaptation of content. Structural transformation generally implies a material alteration of the text.

B. Within established theoretical literature, no systematic formalization has been identified as a model based exclusively on the complete structural reorganization of a work while preserving its textual materiality in absolute terms.

C. This study proposes the formalization of such a model, termed Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT), establishing objective criteria of verifiability.

D. In addition to the theoretical formulation, a previously implemented practical application is presented, enabling the full empirical demonstration of the proposed hypothesis.

2. Definition of the Model

A. Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT) is defined as the structural process through which a complete narrative text is segmented into discrete structural units, each unit preserving its full textual materiality.

B. No word, punctuation mark, syntactic construction, or linguistic element is altered. There is no insertion, suppression, adaptation, or rewriting of any kind.

C. The units are reorganized exclusively through positional displacement, forming a new structural sequence.

D. This reorganization produces a new narrative configuration and a distinct interpretive experience, even though all textual units remain absolutely identical to those of the original text.

E. The model sustains that altering structural order alone may generate a structurally distinct work without any material modification of the textual content.

3. Fundamental Principle

The model is based on the following principle:

The structural reorganization of narrative units, under conditions of absolute textual preservation, may generate a new structural configuration and a distinct interpretive experience without any material modification of the text.

Formal Formulation

Let:

- $I(\cdot)$ be the global interpretive function of the narrative
- T_1 be the original narrative text
- $F = \{f_1, f_2, \dots, f_n\}$ be the ordered set of textual units composing T_1
- σ be a permutation applied to the set F

Define:

$$T_1 = f_1 \circ f_2 \circ \dots \circ f_n$$

where $\circ$ represents structural concatenation.

Applying the permutation σ :

$$T_2 = f_{\sigma(1)} \circ f_{\sigma(2)} \circ \dots \circ f_{\sigma(n)}$$

with the mandatory condition:

$\forall f_i \in F, f_i$ remains textually and materially unaltered.

Then:

- $T_2 \neq T_1$ structurally.
- T_2 and T_1 possess material identity with respect to the set of textual units.

4. Structural Formalization of the Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance (ANIT)

A. Formal Definitions

Let:

- T be a complete narrative text.
- $F = \{f_1, f_2, \dots, f_n\}$ be the ordered set of textual units composing T .
- Each f_i represent an integral textual fragment, indivisible and materially preserved.
- σ be a permutation defined over the set F .

Define:

$$T = f_1 \circ f_2 \circ \dots \circ f_n$$

where $\circ$ represents the structural concatenation of textual units.

B. Structural Reorganization Operator

Define the reorganization operator:

$$R(T, \sigma)$$

such that:

$$T' = f_{\sigma(1)} \circ f_{\sigma(2)} \circ \dots \circ f_{\sigma(n)}$$

with the mandatory condition:

$\forall f_i \in F, f'_i = f_i$

That is:

o fragment undergoes lexical, syntactic, punctuation, or material alteration.

The reorganization is exclusively positional.

C. ANIT Axioms

Axiom 1 — Absolute Textual Invariance

$\forall f_i \in F$, the material content of f_i remains identical before and after reorganization.

No rewriting, insertion, suppression, or adaptation occurs.

Axiom 2 — Global Material Identity

The set of textual units of T' is identical to the set of textual units of T .

Formally:

$$F(T') = F(T)$$

Axiom 3 — Structural Variability

If $\sigma \neq \text{identity}$, then:

$T' \neq T$ structurally.

That is, the order of units' changes while the content remains intact.

Axiom 4 — Global Interpretive Variability

There may exist at least one permutation σ such that:

$$I(T') \neq I(T)$$

where I represents the global interpretive experience.

In other words:

Structural reorganization may generate distinct narrative realities without altering the textual material.

D. Fundamental Proposition

There exists at least one permutation σ such that:

$$R(T, \sigma) = T'$$

where:

- T' is structurally distinct from T ;
- No word has been modified;
- The resulting narrative configuration produces an ontologically distinct interpretation.

E. Theoretical Consequence

ANIT demonstrates that:

Structure $\neq$ Material Content

and that:

Narrative Meaning = $f(\text{Order})$

Therefore:

Order functions as an ontological operator of narrative configuration.

5. Criteria of Textual Invariance

Reaffirming the previous axioms, the following operational conditions are established for the validity of ANIT.

A. Linguistic Integrity

Any intentional linguistic alteration of the textual units is prohibited, including:

- substitution of words;
- insertion of new passages;
- suppression of content;
- partial or total rewriting;
- alteration of syntactic constructions;
- intentional modification of meaning.

Minor typographical adjustments or formal corrections are admissible only if applied identically across all compared versions and without impact on the linguistic content.

B. Material Identity of the Set

The reorganized version must contain exactly the same set of fragments as the original version.

Formally:

$$F(T') = F(T)$$

The following are not permitted:

- creation of new fragments;
- creation of new fragments;
- later fusion or division of units;
- internal reordering within a fragment.

C. Operational Exclusivity

The only permitted transformation is the positional reorganization of the previously defined units.

No internal modification is allowed.

D. Structural Narrative Coherence

Structural reorganization must result in a coherent, autonomous, and interpretatively consistent narrative configuration.

Arbitrary or random permutation of fragments is not permitted.

The new ordering must sustain a valid, intelligible, and internally articulated narrative capable of producing a complete interpretive experience.

The new ordering must sustain a valid, intelligible, and internally articulated narrative capable of producing a complete interpretive experience.

E. Textual Integrity and Technical Limits

The textual structure of each fragment must be fully preserved, including punctuation, discursive markers, and syntactic resources. Any intentional alteration that modifies meaning, tone, or narrative function is prohibited.

Deliberate modifications intended to generate interpretive effects through internal alteration of the text are not permitted.

Eventual typographical variations or unintentional formatting differences — resulting from file conversion, editorial standardization, or graphic adjustments — do not invalidate the model, provided they do not imply semantic, structural, or discursive modification of the content.

6. Demonstrated Application

The model was applied to a literary short story completed in 2025 and later published in digital format. The same structural experiment was subsequently replicated in the translated version of the work, demonstrating that the model operates independently of the specific language in which the text is written.

Two complete versions of the same work were produced:

- **Version A** — Original linear structure.
- **Version B** — Structure reorganized through positional permutation of the textual units.

Both versions:

- contain exactly the same set of textual fragments;
- maintain absolute material identity;

- fully preserve all linguistic units;
- present a distinct structural configuration;
- produce ontologically different narrative outcomes.

In Version A, the narrative configuration culminates in posthumous forgiveness.

In Version B, the narrative configuration culminates in forgiveness during life.

However, the structural reorganization does not affect only the outcome of the narrative. The repositioning of textual units modifies the attribution of events, actions, and narrative roles within the story.

Depending on the structural configuration, the same textual fragments may be interpreted as referring to different characters or narrative circumstances. Statements may be attributed to different agents, and the consequences of events may affect different individuals.

Thus, the underlying narrative material remains strictly identical, while the structural architecture alone generates a distinct global interpretive configuration.

7. Distinction from Existing Models

ANIT should not be confused with:

- conventional non-linear narrative;
- traditional circular structures;
- metafiction;
- mirror narratives;
- modernist fragmentary structures;
- interactive hypertexts.

In such models, narrative transformation may involve:

- partial rewriting;
- suppression of passages;
- textual adaptation;
- semantic alteration;
- authorial intervention in the linguistic materiality of the text.

The central distinction of ANIT lies in the complete structural reorganization of a narrative work while preserving the textual materiality in absolute terms.

There is no rewriting.

There is no internal variation.

There is no insertion or suppression.

There is only the verifiable positional displacement of previously defined textual units.

8. Theoretical Implication

The model demonstrates that:

- narrative perception depends directly on the structural architecture applied to the text;
- chronological linearity constitutes only one among multiple possible orderings;
- narrative identity may vary structurally without any alteration of textual materiality;
- structure functions as a configurational operator capable of producing distinct narrative realities under identical material content.

ANIT shows that the formal organization of textual units actively participates in the ontological constitution of narrative.

9. Epistemological Foundation

Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance is grounded in the distinction between:

- formal structure;
- textual materiality.

The model maintains that narrative experience does not depend exclusively on semantic alteration or textual rewriting, but may emerge from the structural reorganization of previously consolidated and materially preserved content.

The proposal is situated within the field of structural narrative theory, advancing it by establishing objective and verifiable criteria of absolute textual invariance.

It differs from traditional non-linear narrative models by completely eliminating any form of rewriting, adaptation, suppression, or textual insertion.

ANIT formally introduces the notion of structure as an ontological operator of narrative configuration, demonstrating that the positional arrangement of fragments can produce distinct interpretive experiences without any material alteration of the text.

10. Conclusion

Narrative Architecture of Textual Invariance constitutes an original structural model, demonstrated through practical application and validated by rigorous criteria of absolute material preservation.

The model establishes that the complete structural reorganization of textual units may generate a new narrative configuration and a distinct interpretive experience without any rewriting, insertion, suppression, or modification of the original text.

Order therefore operates as an ontological operator of narrative production.

11. Full Empirical Demonstration

To prevent any partial contestation of the hypothesis, the complete versions of the work used as the object of demonstration are presented in Annexes I and II.

Both versions contain exactly the same set of textual units, preserving absolute material identity and differing exclusively in the structural reorganization of the narrative fragments.

The complete comparison allows verification that:

- textual materiality remains identical;
- the set of fragments is invariant;
- the difference lies exclusively in the structural architecture applied.

The internal numbering of fragments is used solely as a methodological instrument of verifiability and does not constitute an aesthetic element of the work.

A) Computational Validation

In addition to the full manual comparison, automated validation was performed through a script written in Python, designed to extract, normalize, and compare the numbered textual units block by block.

The computational procedure:

- extracts exclusively numbered fragments;
- ignores line breaks and irrelevant typographical variations;
- performs block-by-block comparison;
- identifies specific divergences by fragment number;
- verifies absolute identity of content, including punctuation.

The execution result confirmed:

ABSOLUTE TEXTUAL IDENTITY BETWEEN THE VERSIONS.

The complete source code is presented in Annex III.

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ANNEX I

Complete Sequential Version (suiböM)

Originally published in the work *Möbius & suiböM*.

The numbering of textual fragments is used exclusively as a methodological instrument for structural verification.

SALGADO, Bruno. *Möbius & suiböM*. Digital edition. 2026.

ISBN: (9798232583873)

Available on international digital publishing platforms.

suiböM

The morning was born with a rare delicacy, the kind that seems intent on rebuilding the world from the first slit of light. The sky, still damp with blue, yielded to soft shades of rose drifting slowly across thin clouds; and the birds, awake before anyone else, stitched the silence with gentle songs, ushering in the day like an announcement of renewal. Through the half-open curtains, daylight slipped into the bedroom with the caution of something unwilling to disturb anything sacred — only to savor it. He woke first, contemplating her sleeping face beneath the faint glow of dawn, and leaned closer with the tenderness of someone who had finally understood the value of staying. The kiss placed upon her forehead was light, almost a breath, yet enough for her eyes to open slowly. She found him there, so near, with that same look she had known from their first meeting — a look whole, passionate, unguarded, recognizing and surrendering all at once. They remained that way for a moment no clock would dare measure, embraced as if the entire world could fit within that shared breath. The warmth of their bodies drew together with the natural ease of things that had never ceased to belong to one another; and, wrapped in the quiet of morning, they gave themselves to love without haste, as though sealing in silence a promise at last finding its home. Later, they rose together in a tacit agreement of continuity, letting the dawn complete what their gestures had begun — and went, side by side, into another day, as if life itself had just been newly inaugurated for them both. (1)

“Get up from this bed, my love.” (2)

“I love when you call me that.” (3)

“Looks like I danced just right between your hips.” (4)

“Of course, dear.” — The reply came promptly, drawing a smile. (5)

“Make sure you don’t forget.” (6)

“What!?” (7)

“I can’t believe you’re asking me that — it’s even on TV.” (8)

“The medical school graduation ball tonight.” (9)

The question came gently, almost as if afraid of spoiling the rare sweetness of that morning — whether they might have breakfast together, a small but habitual gesture, the kind that builds the quiet intimacy of a day. The answer came quickly, wrapped in haste and lateness: no, not today, they had overslept. The sound of that refusal left in him a small, almost childish disarray, which a discreet smile tried to conceal. Even so, his eyes followed her movements — hurried, yet affectionate — and for a few brief seconds wished time could be held by the edge, just to prolong that simple moment which, suddenly, felt too important to lose. (10)

“Come on, help me zip up this dress.” (11)

“Yes, madam — with great pleasure, my love.” (12)

“I hate that sarcasm of yours.” (13)

Some time later, in the heart of another setting... (14)

“Good morning.” (15)

Good morning, my beloved daughter. Not a single word actually left; it remained buried within — thought stilled in its depths. (16)

“That’s polite, isn’t it?” (17)

“What was that?!” (18)

“I wished you good morning.” (19)

“Good morning, my beloved daughter. I’m exhausted from last night — forgive me.”
(20)

“My mother — where is she?” (21)

“Looks like she went back to sleep. And speaking of that, you went to bed early yesterday — what kind of miracle was that?” (22)

“I guess it was boredom!” (23)

“I’m worried. Your mother’s taking too long, could it be...” (24)

“There she is!” (25)

“I insist, dear, join us — let’s have breakfast together.” (26)

“I can’t. I’ll have breakfast at the hospital.” (27)

“You’d better eat before you go.” (28)

“I’m on my way out.” (29)

“Go on, you can go.” (30)

“A kiss. I won’t be long.” (31)

“Alright then, it’s settled.” (32)

“What’s going on with her?!” (33)

“Still not used to it? Should be by now.” (34)

“That’s true. You’re right.” (35)

Moments later, a vibration shattered the brief stretch of silence, insistent as if demanding an answer. The phone lit up on the surface, revealing only the word “Work” on the screen — an unexpected notice, out of place in the ordinary flow of things. There was a flicker of hesitation, the kind in which even breathing seems heavier than it should be, and the hand moving toward the device trembled with almost imperceptible doubt. The vibration persisted, pulsing like a reminder of something that could not be ignored. At last, a finger slid across the screen to answer. (36)

From the outside, anyone listening would have heard only a monologue — words cast into the air in reply to a voice that reached no one else’s ears. (37)

“Hello.” Three simple letters, still heavy with sleep as they left the vocal cords. (38)

“You are...” (39)

“Why?” (40)

“I think I’m more sober than ever!” (41)

“I’ve just received the coordinates.” (42)

“I understand perfectly. I’m always at your disposal, ma’am. You may call me at any hour — I’ll attend to you with great pleasure.” (43)

“Yes!” (44)

“Absolutely. I am fully conscious.” (45)

He ended the call, and a sudden tightness crossed his chest — brief yet sharp, as though something inside had shifted out of place. That call had not been expected, least of all on a Sunday, and the strangeness of the timing stirred a small, silent unrest in his thoughts. He remained still for a few seconds, the device still warm in his palm, trying to sort through what he felt, but nothing aligned at once: only a diffuse discomfort, an unease rising from somewhere deeper than reason could reach. (46)

“Strange, on a Sunday?” Thought aloud. (47)

“I’m heading out, my daughter. Behave yourself. I’ll be back soon — don’t go anywhere.” (48)

He grabbed the car keys quickly and left without saying anything more. (49)

In the parallel fragment of that same moment... (50)

In a slow gesture, still marked by the weight of the late night, a hand reached for the device beside the bed. The face carried that warm, rumpled softness — the gentle imprint of a night consumed in skin and breath; half-closed eyes held the lingering density left by passion that had filled every hour. The alarm was silenced, and the head tilted just enough to catch the time — and in the brief silence that followed, there seemed to be regret at the simple fact that the day had begun. A new cycle came the voiceless murmur. The motel sign, which hours earlier had pulsed sweet and complicit like a forbidden promise, now lay dark, neutralized by the raw light of dawn. Each ray slipping through the crack in the curtain did not illuminate: it exposed. Where pleasure had been, bitterness remained; where the night had seemed to conceal, the day revealed without mercy. (51)

“Last night was wonderful. I’ll promise you an even better one — just not today.” (52)

“Just once and you’d already be in love with me?” (53)

“You’d better hurry, or you’ll be late.” (54)

“You know... now that I think about it, I already am — a few extra minutes more or less won’t matter after such sweet memories. I’m a master at inventing excuses.” Spoken with a hint of self-satisfaction. (55)

“With all due respect, my sweet dear, if anyone sees us leaving this place, what will they think...” A faint sigh followed, as though the thought had slipped away on its own. (56)

“We always knew the risk of our situation.” (57)

“Do you think I want us identified?” (58)

“She knows!” (59)

“Who knows what?” (60)

“My wife. And I’m telling you — if she calls you and you’re not convincing enough to prove my innocence, the one who will find out is your spouse.” (61)

“Disgusting cretinism!” (62)

“I have no intention of arguing. I’m simply informing you that from now on, seek whoever you wish — just not me.” (63)

“What do you mean — to sleep with me?!” (64)

“I don’t want to be complicit in this.” (65)

“Complicit? You were the impure act itself. I see no complicity — only cowardice.” (66)

“You see? I’m never understood by you!” (67)

“There’s nothing left for us to talk about.” (68)

“You’re impossible — always ironic, always harsh. I don’t know what else to do.” (69)

“Oh! After indulging in every inch of someone else’s body, it’s easy to talk. Speak, hypocrite!” (70)

“You’re making a mountain out of a molehill.” (71)

“You speak like every guilty soul claiming innocence. Cowardice! Filth!” (72)

In a brief moment, there was an interruption — a knock at the door. (73)

“Good morning, ma’am?” (74)

“I’ll step out. I’ll leave you two alone.” (75)

“No need. You can stay.” (76)

“I think it’s better if I don’t. Excuse me.” (77)

“Your driver is waiting for you in the comfort of your luxury car’s air-conditioning. Don’t be late.” Spoken with irony. (78)

“How nice — I have a private driver at my disposal!” Exclaimed in the same mocking tone. (79)

“Goodbye, ingratitude. And yet I’m the only one who’s ironic!” (80)

The expression hardened, and the door was slammed shut. (81)

What she had just heard unsettled her stride — she nearly stumbled, as if legs and thoughts had collided at once. (82)

She hurried forward; yet the instant the staircase began beneath her feet, something extinguished the world around her — sound recoiled as though swallowed whole, light lost its substance — and the body gave way. Step after step, it tumbled down, as if torn from its own axis, rolling to the bottom in brutal silence. (83)

“Ma’am, can you hear me?” (84)

“What happened?” (85)

“You fell down the stairs.” (86)

“I don’t remember.” (87)

“That’s normal after fainting.” (88)

“How are you feeling?” (89)

“Fine, don’t worry. I’m alright. How long was I unconscious?” (90)

“You were unconscious for a few hours.” (91)

A disconsolate expression crossed her face in the middle of the exchange, and she said: (92)

“I’m late!” Spoken in a lamenting tone, almost palpable, as if the entire night had been spent awake. (93)

“You’re not in any condition. I strongly recommend that you—” (94)

“I have to go!” (95)

“Are you sure you’re not feeling anything?” (96)

“I’m shaken. I didn’t sleep properly, that’s all!” Cut short, rising to her feet. (97)

In the space where vehicles rest before new journeys: (98)

“Are you alright, ma’am?” The question came again, edged with concern. (99)

“Yes, I’m fine.” (100)

“Forgive the interruption without notice.” (101)

“You’re only doing your job. I understand.” (102)

“I appreciate that. I’m glad.” (103)

“Thank you. I return the courtesy. I have no intention of dragging you into gossip — nor myself. That’s why you are exclusively mine. The best driver there is.” (104)

“It’s fine.” The reply came strained, almost caught in the throat. (105)

They got into the car and left the parking lot with a certain urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus. At the wheel, a disconcerting smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — and, in a strange lapse, almost vertigo, stillness took hold for a few seconds, as if that moment had already been lived, a *déjà vu* that asked no permission. A breath was drawn, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always brought to mind his own, words sliding out of alignment with the present moment: “You are more beloved than my own wife.” She turned her face just enough to follow with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the lapse, “things that appear without asking,” it continued, while the car moved forward, suspended between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken. (106)

“We’ve arrived.” Said in a tone tinged with melancholy and a certain unrest. (107)

“Bastard, what’s that supposed to mean — more beloved than your own wife?” Said with an ironic, uncomfortable edge. (108)

As if fleeing the answer, the door was opened quickly and, like a gentleman, the passenger side was reached and opened for her. (109)

“It was only an involuntary reaction to a strong emotional impact.” (110)

“Emotional impact? That’s what I had — it felt like the world was about to collapse in an instant!” (111)

“For that, I apologize.” (112)

“You should. You look like you’re drifting in the clouds, not paying attention.” (113)

“But I still have something to tell you—” (114)

“Do you want me to be late?! What could possibly be so important?!” Cut short. (115)

“I am requesting my resignation right now!” Spoken in a raised tone. (116)

“Watch how you speak to me. I am not your daughter! I am your boss!” (117)

“Have you lost your mind? What’s gotten into you—” (118)

“I have not!” Cut off abruptly. (119)

“What I mean is... how am I supposed to explain that I was working on a Sunday?”
(120)

“Here, take your payment. That way you can prove to your wife that you were working — before she kills you,” exclaimed with irony. “Daddy!” (121)

“I deserve it.” Spoken with a trace of self-contempt. (122)

“I have nothing more to discuss with you, ma’am. Good day.” (123)

“You did it! Consider the money I gave you your final salary. You’re fired! Bastard!”
(124)

“Great! Saint!” (125)

A glance at the clock display brought a jolt of reality — time had not waited; it had rushed forward, relentless and unbroken — not wound by batteries, nor subject to anyone’s will. A hurried departure followed, straight home. (126)

“I’m home!” Exclaimed with urgency. (127)

“Mom’s been at the hospital since early this morning.” (128)

“Damn! I’ll call her right now.” (129)

The phone was picked up, breath still warm from the previous exchange, the tone adjusted to sound awake, ordinary. When the call connected, the sound of the hospital came with it — hurried footsteps, distant voices, and scattered fragments cutting across the line: (130)

“Heart rate...” (131)

“Bring the defibrillator...” (132)

Phone ringing. (133)

“Clear the airway...” (134)

Agitated voices... (135)

“Move him to the OR...” (136)

The phone was moved slightly away to give a quick instruction, then brought back with breath still uneven, explaining it was only hospital routine and that the graduating students were helping with preparations for the celebration. A question followed — whether enough rest had been had to accompany her that night — and the reply came, with the slight hesitation of someone improvising, that the boss had sent him on an unusual trip and the return had been late — the reason for sounding somewhat unsettled. A tired sigh followed, but without suspicion, saying that once finished, she would head straight home and that some rest should be taken to be in proper condition for the big evening. A few more words were exchanged — tender, brief — and the call ended with the promise of arriving in time to get ready for the ball. (137)

When the clock had just passed the solar weight of noon — by only a few minutes. (138)

The rhythm of knocks at the door brought alarm, footsteps quickening to open it, with a trace of apprehension. (139)

“Mr. Gustavo Almeida, if—” (140)

“Yes, this is the place!” Interrupted abruptly by a man who appeared middle-aged; before the sentence could be completed, the uniform had already been recognized. (141)

“Can you receive—” (142)

“Yes! I’m his daughter!” The impatience of youth speaking faster. (143)

“Here’s a package for him.” (144)

“Thank you very much.” (145)

“You’re welcome, miss.” (146)

“Hmph! Kids these days.” Spoken from a short distance away. (147)

The door was closed, the package placed on the table, still sealed, the headphones returned to their place — and the whole world went mute before the music. (148)

In a synchronization almost rehearsed, the mother entered right after, quietly placing a hand on the shoulders. (149)

“I didn’t see you come in — you scared me!” (150)

“You walk around with that thing shoved in your ears. What did you expect?” (151)

The girl fell silent, her face shifting into an expression that clearly revealed incomprehension and disdain. (152)

“Where’s your father?” (153)

“He’s upstairs sleeping.” (154)

“Ever since that call he made to me? It’s almost time for us to leave for the ball.” (155)

“I don’t know if it was before or after. What I do know is that he left and came back some time later.” (156)

“Left? Went where?” (157)

“He didn’t say. Just mentioned he was heading out. When he came back, he went straight upstairs and went back to sleep.” (158)

The stairs were taken slowly, steps that seemed to float between the distant noise of the house and the silence always found in that room. At the half-open door, a pause — watching him lying there, motionless, too serene for someone merely asleep. The light filtering through the narrow gap in the curtains traced along him an almost sacred outline, as if time itself preserved that stillness intact. A few short steps closer, breathing in his presence like someone returning to an old harbor. Leaning down, lips touched his face — a light kiss, almost a breath — and in that same instant a subtle shiver passed through his body, as though the tenderness of the gesture had crossed the wall of sleep and reached some inner place where she was still felt, even far from any waking hour. (159)

A shake came with a trace of unease. His eyes opened, and a smile appeared for that face so deeply admired. (160)

“What happened?” (161)

“It’s almost time to go — the ball, remember?!” (162)

“Have you been drinking?” (163)

“Just two drinks. Nothing excessive.” (164)

“Of course!” (165)

“Don’t be mad at me. Try to understand — what can I say?” (166)

“I don’t know. Some people really have no sense of risk — driving and still drinking.” (167)

The couple prepared for the ball with the quiet solemnity of those rehearsing an ancient ritual: she adjusting her hair before the vanity, he straightening his tie with the slight hesitation of someone trying to lend the moment a touch of perfection; the bedroom carried the warm scent of freshly pressed fabric, and the house seemed wrapped in a silence of expectation. The jacket was slipped on, a deep breath drawn, and the wardrobe door slid shut; as the mirror ran along its tracks, it returned his own image — and then the world failed. For less than a second, a tear in reality: behind him, reflected with cruel precision, his wife appeared in the same dress meant for the ball, but drenched in blood from nape to ankles, the strands of fabric clinging to her skin as though torn from a nightmare; the reflection pulsed, trembling, too alive. His eyes widened, the air split in his chest — and everything vanished. In her place, only the ordinary reflection remained: a woman smiling, intact, adjusting her bracelet, asking naturally whether the tie was straight. He blinked twice, trying to recover his balance, and answered as best he could, keeping to himself the sudden fright, the impression that something had stared back from the other side of the glass. (168)

Noticing a faint pallor on his face, a question followed: (169)

“Is everything alright?” (170)

Silent he remained; silent he stayed. (171)

“I’m furious with you!” (172)

“What is it?” (173)

“Enough! I can’t keep this bottled up inside me anymore!” (174)

“Keep what?!” (175)

“Whatever it is you’ve been doing behind my back!” (176)

“That’s absurd. You know I would never—” (177)

“Funny — with all that conviction, I’m the only one who doesn’t buy it! I always knew. Always. I only kept quiet because something bigger was meant to happen today, and I wasn’t going to let everything collapse because of your — borrowed courage!” (178)

“You’re twisting everything! You’re hearing only what you want to hear!” (179)

“I’m tired! Tired of you thinking you lie so well!” (180)

“You know that from the very first moment I saw you, what I feel for you has been firm as rock.” (181)

A hesitation to argue back; posture recomposed, words left unspoken: “Bastard. In someone else’s arms, indulging himself; they’re all the same — he must say the same thing to the other one.” (182)

“You were seen — I mean, your car was seen leaving the motel, and someone told me. The motel right next to the hospital where I work. On a Sunday. Where was your head?” (183)

“Here, call my boss. She’s the one who called me to pick her up at the motel — and yes, I found it strange too. On a Sunday.” (184)

“What kind of filthy fetish is that? Isn’t there enough of that at home?” (185)

“It’s not my fault!” (186)

“You’re already inventing another story. I remember you telling me you came home agitated because of a trip.” (187)

“Yes! And I wasn’t lying. I did make a trip — I just didn’t know where I was going. I received the coordinates on my phone; I didn’t even notice. When I realized, I was inside the motel. How was I supposed to explain that to you, with your constant rush?” (188)

“You shouldn’t have gone in!” (189)

“I already did!” (190)

“What did you do?” (191)

“If I hadn’t, I would’ve been fired on the spot. I lost my nerve for a moment, but it doesn’t matter — I resigned.” (192)

A faint creak of the door came with an unsettling exclamation — (193)-

“Are you fighting?!” Interrupted by the impatient voice of the daughter. (194)

“Of course not, my daughter. Just a brief flare of tempers between us.” (195)

With the instinct to cut through the tension taking shape: (196)

“There’s a package on the table. It was delivered for you, Dad.” (197)

“Yes, thank you for reminding me, my daughter.” (198)

“Alright, Dad. There’s just one more thing I want to tell you: even when I’m a little sharp, I’ve never stopped loving you — and I never will.” Spoken with such emotion that he felt touched, sheltered by an almost angelic tenderness. (199)

“Oh, my love, I do too.” (200)

Right after those words, she threw herself into her father’s arms, like someone reclaiming a long-awaited presence; then moved toward her mother, driven by the same impulse for comfort that seemed to run through the entire house. (201)

The conversation resumed, tempers less inflamed: (202)

“Let’s leave the past where it belongs — behind us, please. I know you have reasons to doubt; you’re tired, but I’m only asking for a moment of your attention.” (203)

Consent came without strength to argue. Collapse felt near, helpless before everything that had unfolded. (204)

“It’s the medical school graduation ball. You know I can’t miss it.” (205)

“Alright. We’ll talk when you’re calmer.” (206)

The couple got into the car and left the parking lot without any urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus; at the wheel, a distant smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — when, in an abrupt jolt, the car braked hard to avoid something crossing ahead, splitting the silence for a brief second. A breath was recovered, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always reminded him of his own,

words slipping out of alignment with the moment: “You are more beloved than my own wife.” She turned her face just enough to follow him with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that same slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the shock of the sudden brake, “things that appear without asking,” it continued, while the car moved forward between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken — as though traveling through a fold in time. (207)

“What’s that supposed to mean — ‘more beloved than my wife’? Am I no longer your wife?” (208)

“Of course you are! I meant you are deeply loved; it must have been memory playing tricks on me after what just happened.” (209)

“Yes! I know — just two drinks, that’s the explanation.” Spoken ironically. (210)

“My love, we’re almost there; let’s not ruin the mood — you look stunning.” (211)

The car glided into the illuminated parking lot, and when the doors opened, there was a brief — almost imperceptible — instant in which the atmosphere seemed to change texture, as though a veil had been lifted from the world. Stepping out, they walked side by side, fingers intertwined, with that rare kind of harmony that exists only when two realities touch without noticing. The lights from the hall reflected against the asphalt, washing the approaching faces in gold; and as they crossed the entrance, there lingered a sensation — sweet for one, vertiginous for the other — that they had passed through that threshold before, though no memory existed to justify such familiarity. (212)

“Well, here we are.” Said with a discreet smile. (213)

In the golden hall, where chandeliers poured light in cascading streams and crystal seemed to breathe in rhythm with the orchestra, they moved across the floor like two people who had been dancing within each other long before learning any steps. Her dress — fluid, almost liquid fabric — followed each turn, kindling small auroras along its edges, while his suit shaped the assured posture of someone who recognizes himself in the gaze of the woman he loves. The scent of jasmine mingled with the violins, and when the opening melody began — the one she had always called their song — her smile unfolded with the softness of a slow dawn, the kind no one dares to interrupt. Guests watched, but nothing intruded: between them existed a private world, silent, perfect, where steps ceased to be steps and became promises; where touch outweighed any word; where dancing together was a form of prayer. And as they turned

beneath the hall's star-lit ceiling, happiness settled upon them like light upon skin — a simple, ancient certainty that they would remain side by side for as long as time allowed. (214)

And within the entwined steps of destiny's Möbius dance, the wind whispered like words not spoken by the body, yet spoken through it. (215)

"What an extraordinary woman you are... so beautiful, so sensual, offering me one of the most remarkable nights of my life. Your company feels like the touch of forbidden angels, and I desire you eternally. Tonight you shone like a dancing angel. I understand your strength and your delicate touch, but — today, tomorrow, or at any time — I will be your guide, leading you toward your destiny. As I always will be, my love." (216)

Spoken for the night, for the day, for what was yet to come and for what had already passed. (217)

The music ended as though slowly gathering a veil back into itself, and the hall seemed to loosen its shoulders after so many emotions set in motion. The lights softened, revealing tired faces, lingering smiles, the shimmer of champagne in forgotten glasses. Gradually, conversations resumed in small circles — a compliment exchanged here, a hurried embrace there — while waiters moved between still-crowded tables, collecting remnants of a celebration that seemed reluctant to end. One by one, the graduates shed their ceremonial poses, tucking diplomas beneath their arms like newly entrusted promises. The décor lost its initial splendor, and the hall began that quiet dismantling that happens only after a celebration has fulfilled its purpose. Among them, they were among the first to rise, drifting out of the still-warm atmosphere shaped by the final chords, leaving behind the mingled haze of perfume, glitter, and farewells — as though the night, for them, required another kind of continuation. (218)

"My love, I have a surprise for you." (219)

"What kind of surprise?" (220)

"It's been sitting on our table at home for a while. I know these past days haven't been easy for you — that you've been hurt, shaken — maybe you didn't even notice." Spoken with a slow shake of the head. (221)

"I'm eager to reach our destination. I hope you'll dance on me just the way you already did." (222)

"Unfortunately, I'll have to deny you that. Not tonight!" (223)

“What did you go there for?” (224)

“I’ll say it again — I only went to pick her up where I told you. Please, believe me.”
(225)

“It’s not fair. I can’t just ignore it.” (226)

“What’s not fair is being held responsible for someone else’s irresponsibility!” (227)

“Still angry with me?” (228)

“What do you think?!” (229)

They left the hall still wrapped in music that seemed unwilling to release their bodies, walking slowly through the golden light spilling from the main doors; he, smiling a little too loosely, moved with that moist brightness in the eyes of someone who drank more than admitted, and she, holding his hand with discreet firmness, sensed the faint sway in his steps — almost imperceptible to anyone else, yet unmistakable to one who knows the weight and rhythm of the beloved — and though their laughter echoed through the parking lot, there was in her posture a growing tension, a quick glance at the key between his fingers, another at the car waiting in the dimness, then at the sky, as if silently measuring the distance between the joy of that night and the unpredictable risk that can fit within a single step too many. (230)

“Come on, doctor, pick up the pace! I’m your private driver.” Spoken with irony. (231)

“Stop being cute. Give me the car keys.” (232)

“F-for... what?... that? I’m... fine. Want me to... walk a straight line?” (233)

“I’m not joking. You can’t even form a full sentence!” (234)

“Look at me! I would never put you in any embarrassing or dangerous situation like you’re implying!” (235)

“Implying?! I’m stating it! Give me that key! I’m driving!” (236)

“You don’t trust me to drive anymore?” (237)

“Lately everything I do seems to displease you. I don’t know what else I can possibly do. I ask you for the car key and you—” (238)

“Absolutely not. I already told you — either you take public transport or I drive you.”
Cut off harshly. (239)

“It’s Sunday. Public transport takes forever!” (240)

“Don’t shout at me. It’s not my problem. You see disaster in everything — then let it be that way.” (241)

“I demand your respect. Is that any way to speak? Watch yourself!” (242)

“I’m drunk and you don’t even have a license — so what now?!” (243)

“I’d like to know how long these little jokes of yours are going to continue.” (244)

“Come on, let’s take this road. Sit beside me.” (245)

“I won’t tolerate this disrespect. Let it be the last time.” Reprimanded in a firm, merciless tone. (246)

The door opened, and the passenger seat was taken, as if entering only because no other path remained. (247)

“I’ll find you a better seat. This one doesn’t seem comfortable enough for the Doctor.” (248)

The car was already on the highway when the old argument tried to resurface through her voice: (249)

“You’ve never been this much of a coward before — at a motel near my workplace?” (250)

“Stop! We’re not going to argue about this anymore — at least not now.” (251)

He lowered his head for a brief moment, trying to locate, in the darkness that filled the interior, the radio dial. Even slightly unsteady from the alcohol, he managed to turn it on; the music that began to play muffled the engine’s hum and the weighted silence that lingered between them. It sounded like an inexplicable coincidence — unwanted and yet strangely fitting — and, for a fleeting instant, everything softened into calm, with nostalgia brushing gently against their hearts. (252)

... Now I feel as if I'm floating away

I can't feel all the pressure

And I like it this way

But my body's callin'

My body's callin'

Won't ya come back to this
World again... (253)

“You used to listen to this song all the time.” (254)

“My God! Lord Jesus!” (255)

“Watch out for the car—” (256)

Suddenly, the sound was swallowed by the violent screech of tires — two cars running side by side, one tearing into an overtake while both slammed the brakes at the same instant, unleashing a roar that seemed to stretch for miles, harsh as sharpened claws raking the asphalt and ripping through the stillness of the night. (257)

“Hold the wheel tight! Careful!” (258)

The car lost control, skidding sideways, and the world slipped into slow motion — headlights stretched into liquid blades, the hood jolted upward with a metallic gasp, the windshield burst into hundreds of shards that hovered in the air like suspended ice, each fragment catching the yellow glow of the highway lamps, gentle and lethal upon the asphalt. The sound of the impact did not arrive at once; first came a dense silence, then a muffled crash that seemed to rise from beneath the earth. One of the drivers braked instinctively, untouched by the collision, feeling the seatbelt clamp against the chest, and when the gaze turned toward the other vehicle — almost a mile away — there lay the twisted mass crushed against the guardrail: gray smoke rising, doors pinned shut, metal folded like paper — and, amid the wreckage, a figure crawling out, slow, stubborn, dragging forward with the strength of someone who refuses to die. (259)

The vehicle that had remained intact stood motionless for a few brief minutes, until new headlights appeared on the horizon. Then it accelerated abruptly — tires burning against the asphalt, scattering fragments into the wind — in a sudden, almost instinctive escape, impossible to decipher. (260)

Indefinite minutes slowly unspooled between one act and the next. (261)

Eyes that had remained alert, braced against the world, caught — at the edge of vision — the outline of two headlights approaching the scene: first a slash of light, then the full shape of a vehicle gliding to a stop nearby. There was a subtle shift in posture, almost instinctive, from the one who watched — the gesture of someone who sensed, without needing certainty, that

this moment could mean rescue, or danger, or merely destiny moving a few inches forward. Time seemed to pause before resuming its natural course. (262)

The key turned and the engine's heavy silence dissolved at once, as though the outside world had forced its way into the moment without permission. Mixed sounds — footsteps, voices, scattered noise from a place that never truly sleeps — crossed the air with the urgency of those witnessing something critical. Thoughts, still unsettled, settled against the windshield, blurring the outlines of things as if everything were slightly out of focus. Inside, two bodies remained motionless for an instant that seemed reluctant to end; there was in that arrival a discouragement difficult to name, a weight neither wished to confront. Then the hand that reached for the handle did not hesitate: the door opened with a certain haste, too quick to be casual — whether from fear of being seen or questioned. The opening exposed a brief yet striking moment, the kind time preserves even when memory tries to purge it. After that, everything moved forward, as though there were no choice but to continue. (263)

Before even crossing the entrance, a glowing sign imposed itself like fate: “emergency & urgent care.” (264)

“She’s covered in blood...” (265)

“Calm down!” (266)

“We need to help — come on!” (267)

“Make sure they provide proper care. Don’t worry. Let’s go! Quickly — we need to act now!” (268)

“Take the patient to stabilization...” (269)

“Ahh! What happened... it hurts... my arm...” (270)

“Try to stay awake — you have a head injury...” (271)

“My God... how awful. And some people still complain about life.” (272)

“It’s alright, they’re helping already.” (273)

Noticing the unrest in the expression and the approach of a police officer crossing the courtyard toward the vehicle, the figure quickly returned to the driver’s seat — too late to avoid the unwanted presence. Light knocks echoed against the window; it was the officer, the gesture clearly asking for the window to be lowered. (274)

“You know you can’t park here, right?!” Spoken while pointing toward a traffic sign.
(275)

“I only brought her here... I didn’t want to cause any trouble. She was on the shoulder, so I stopped. I’m leaving, alright?!” (276)

His thoughts tangled into a whirl difficult to name — whether from the weight of the moment or from the instinctive fear certain questions awaken in those who would rather not answer them. There was, within, a haste he tried to conceal: the urgency to distance himself from any doubt, from any interpretation that might fall upon him, fair or not. When it became clear the officer intended to prolong the exchange, the harsh screech of tires against asphalt rose as a preemptive reply. He sped off too quickly, like someone afraid of explanations he would not know how to give, vanishing into the horizon before any word could reach him. (277)

Fragmented phrases flickered like electric flashes crossing trembling synapses — cutting out and reconnecting in chaotic choreography — from a life that insisted, desperately, on remaining, layered beneath the living sound of the hospital rushing to render aid. (278)

“Control the bleeding...” (279)

The frantic rattle of gurney wheels moving at speed. (280)

“Blood pressure dropping...” (281)

“Pupils slightly...” (282)

“I need gloves, now!” (283)

Voices of anguish and urgency filling the emergency room. (284)

“Mobilize the entire—” (285)

“Look, another car is pulling in!” (286)

“Call the orderly!” (287)

Two nurses appeared on the scene, firm steps carrying urgency plainly written across their faces. Fueled by adrenaline — even if it was a familiar surge — they searched for anyone available: one announced that another patient had just arrived in critical condition and that extra hands were needed in the trauma room. The other added, breath still quickened, that the day’s routine had completely unraveled — severe cases arriving back-to-back, leaving no space for the staff to catch their breath. The call echoed through the area like an unavoidable signal,

summoning every nearby professional to move before the next minute grew too heavy to bear.
(288)

“Prep the OR!” (289)

“Looks like it’s going to be one of those days — no smoke breaks!” Spoken to a coworker. (290)

“Well, look who’s walking right past us — what a handsome doctor. That’s what I should be focusing on.” (291)

“Dreams are free. Reality’s right here, my friend.” (292)

“Yeah... life here isn’t easy.” Replied the colleague. (293)

Some time later, within the attentive silence of the hospital environment. (294)

Then, with more urgent steps, like someone jolting awake from a deep sleep, an attempt was made to guide them firmly toward the main entrance; upon entering the central hall, a strange sound — unbearably loud to the ears — reverberated throughout the space. It began with the heavy thud of a heartbeat; for a moment, it seemed to be one’s own. Soon, however, abstract mechanical sounds merged with that rhythm — the pulse of a cardiac monitor intertwined with scattered voices and labored breathing — until the exclamation broke through:
(295)

“What is this chaos?!” Spoken almost in disbelief. (296)

Before the surrounding noise could be deciphered, hurried footsteps echoed across the floor — descending from above, as if someone had been abruptly awakened. A silhouette appeared in urgency, crossing the corridor to wrap you in a firm, nearly desperate embrace. The gesture carried relief, shock, and a tenderness that could not immediately be explained; only the tightness of the hold spoke. The space, once dominated by noise, softened at the touch of that presence, as though saying without words: “You’re here. At last.” (297)

“Where am I... Where is he...” (298)

“I wouldn’t advise that, Doctor.” (299)

“Why not?!” (300)

“Coma.” (301)

“What coma? What are you talking about?” (302)

“You were very lucky. It could have been fatal. The impact was severe, but fortunately the injuries were limited to extensive bruising, a minor wrist fracture — which won’t affect mobility — and a deep laceration to the frontal region, which caused the initial concern. The amount of blood can be alarming, I know, but the bleeding was superficial, despite being heavy. We ran a full series of imaging tests — including an MRI — and there are no signs of swelling, internal bleeding, or neurological impairment. You’re out of danger. You can rest easy.” (303)

“I can’t believe it... this can’t be happening.” (304)

“That was a terrible accident!” (305)

“I need to see my husband.” (306)

“I’m sorry, but there isn’t much we can do...” (307)

“My God, what’s happening?!” (308)

“As I said, he’s in a coma.” (309)

“Don’t worry. I’ll take you to him — it’s more than my duty.” (310)

“I need to call home. I have to speak to my daughter.” (311)

“She’s here. We’ve already arranged for her to come.” (312)

“Who’s here? Where am I?” (313)

“Your daughter.” (314)

And without warning, struck by a sudden wave, she collapsed into her colleague’s arms, who caught her and guided her to a hospital recliner beside a stretcher in room 742. (315)

When she came to, familiar faces hovered over her — shaped by worry and tenderness — still not fully understanding what they had just witnessed. (316)

“Mom! What happened? Oh my God!” (317)

“And your arm — why is it bandaged?” (318)

“It’s nothing serious, just a mild sprain; it’s my head that still hurts.” (319)

“Obviously — from the visible blow to your forehead. You needed stitches.” (320)

“And you still say it was nothing?” (321)

“I’m lucid and fully awake.” (322)

“You should get some rest.” (323)

“I’ll try. Stay with your father.” (324)

“Dad is right here beside us.” (325)

“Unfortunately, I’m seeing him in a way I never wanted to; just keep him company.”
(326)

The sound — continuous, sharp, unexpected — tore through the room like a blade of light, halting time for a breath no one could claim as their own. In the same instant, her hand lunged forward in a primitive reflex, almost an instinct of life trying to summon another; it fell against his chest, striking with the urgency of someone refusing silence. Everything seemed to unfold in slow motion — the weight of her arm descending, breath caught in her throat, the world around her blurring as if sliding off at the edges. His body gave beneath the impact — not like someone awakening, but like someone returning from a place where time does not answer to clocks — at seven-thirty in the morning. (327)

“Mom, is everything okay?” (328)

“It was just a scare, only a scare, thank God.” Attempting to calm her. (329)

Hurried knocks at the door cut through the silence of the room. The girl heard them and went to see who was knocking, her head lowered with emotion — unsettled by her father not being at her side as she wished; he was there, sleeping, yet not living beside her as she longed. (330)

At the instant the Möbius loop turned upon itself (331)

“Is it urgent?” (332)	“What is that infernal noise?” (338)
“I’m just still a little disoriented.” (333)	“It feels like no one hears me when I
“What happened?” The nurse asked.	speak — can’t you hear what I’m
(334)	saying?!” The reply lingered in the air.
	(339)
“I’m fine — I just had a bad feeling.”	
(335)	“Am I stepping into hell?!” The murmur
	continued, as if addressed to no one.
“I’m calm now.” (336)	(340)
“What bad feeling?” No answer	
followed. (337)	“Where is your mother?” (341)

“Did you hear that?!” The voice came startled. (342)

“Yes, I heard you clearly.” (343)

“No — not me. As if there were someone else speaking besides us.” (344)

“For God’s sake! Are you hearing voices now?” (345)

“Never mind. It must’ve just been my imagination, given the situation.” (346)

A little further on, when the next moment finally announced itself... (347)

“It’s that Guns N’ Roses song you loved so much, Dad.” (348)

“I wish you could hear me; we need you. You have to rise again... please, get up.” (349)

“Turn that down, my daughter!” (350)

“This can’t be happening.” The thought slipped out while the device was turned off. (351)

“Oh, great! At this rate they’ll lock me in a cage — I can’t do anything!” (352)

“Daughter, either it’s that heavy rock—” (353)

“See how you all treat me?!” (354)

“I know you seem to like nothing but chaos!” (355)

“Indifferent to my presence, as always — he’ll never come out of that coma.” The words came in the heat of the music and the familiar sense of distance, even when he was awake. (356)

“God forbid such a dark hour!” (357)

“I’ll turn it down... he seems indifferent to everything; not even music reaches him anymore.” The voice carried a quiet weariness, almost condemning the father’s presence — so near, yet so far. (358)

“I’m sorry for yelling at you, my daughter; my head’s been racing, and I understand what you’re going through.” (359)

“I’m always the one who has to understand. I just wanted to escape this loneliness for a while.” (360)

“I know, my daughter. I’m just not up to that right now, please.” (361)

When the moment — still warm — was torn open by a summons that asked no permission. (362)

“You need to go home and rest, Doctor; I’m prescribing a sedative. Go home and lie down for a while.” (363)

“But I have—” (364)

“I’m not speaking as your colleague, but as your physician. No ‘but.’ You fainted in my arms.” (365)

“I’ll call an Uber, don’t worry.” (366)

“Then go, rest and recover; everything will be fine.” (367)

“Thank you, but I don’t need medication.” (368)

“Listen to me — as a doctor yourself, take the sedatives.” (369)

“I understand. I know.” (370)

“It’s my duty as a physician to help.” (371)

“Stay here, my daughter!” (372)

“I will. I’ll pull myself together, take a shower, clear my head.” (373)

“See you soon, Mom.” The voice trembled amid the confusion. (374)

“I’m going home.” (375)

A sigh was heard — deep, forceful — as if carried from some forewarning beyond. It made her tear the headphones from her ears and look up in unease, as though touched by something spectral, turning her face toward whoever had just reached for her. (376)

“Are you trying to scare me to death?!” (377)

“I’m sorry for startling you.” (378)

“Good grief! Didn’t you just leave?!” (379)

“I forgot my wallet; could you hand it to me? The one right there beside you, please.” (380)

“Try speaking to him; he always listened to you. Even in the state he’s in now, it’s possible he can still hear you.” (381)

“I try to gather the courage to talk to him, but he’s so different.” (382)

“How is your father?” (383)

“You’re asking me that? Didn’t you hear?” (384)

“I did. That’s why I’m asking — so you’ll reflect. What I see is that there’s life in him, as there is in you; only death has no remedy — everything else can be mended.” (385)

“Call if anything happens, please.” (386)

“Now I really am leaving. A kiss.” (387)

“Another. Drive carefully. God be with you.” (388)

“As I said, I’m not driving; I’ll call an Uber or a taxi.” (389)

The car traced the winding curve into the familiar stretch of the street that led home. The engine breathed out, slow and weary, before falling silent at the gate. The sky seemed undecided between night and day, and the cold wind carried the scent of earth, of

dawn, of something interrupted. For a moment, everything stood still — the shuttered windows, the yard still glazed with dew, the door heavy with too many memories. Then the car door opened slowly, and a figure stepped out, hesitant, with steps that betrayed neither guilt nor exhaustion nor simply too much truth for that hour. It lingered there, motionless before its own shadow, breathing the kind of air that belongs only to beginnings one does not wish for. And, as if releasing a sentence that refused to die, murmured to the rising day: (390)

— “Bitter home, home...” (391)

Meanwhile, in the couple’s house: (392)

A phone already gripped in trembling hands and thick, confused thoughts waited only a second before dialing — that second in which silence seems to measure fate. On the other side, when the screen lit up, the brief vibration traveled across the table like an intimate warning, almost premonitory. The number displayed brought neither comfort nor threat — only immediate recognition, the kind that awakens relief and vertigo at once. The ringing persisted, filling the space with a tightening sensation, and both worlds — the one calling and the one answering — seemed to converge within the same suspended breath. A finger slid to accept the call. (393)

“Hello.” (394)

“Who is this?” (395)

“You’re disgusting!” (396)

“Excuse me? Who do you think you’re talking to?!” (397)

“To a woman who opens herself to any man.” (398)

“What happened, my dear?!” (399)

“Don’t you dare throw baseless accusations at me. Who do you think you are?”
(400)

“Pathetic!” (401)

“Why are you insulting me like this? I don’t have to stand here listening to this—
” (402)

“But I’m the one being cheated on, aren’t I?!” The interruption came in a shout.
(403)

“Now I see the number you called from. My apologies — I wasn’t paying attention. I know exactly who this is. Mrs.— I mean, Doctor.” (403-2)

“Did you think I was your lover?!” (404)

“My lover? My— whatever! Mr. Gustavo Almeida, let this be clear to everyone, is only my driver.” (405)

“Particularly personal, very close.” (406)

“Stop with the insinuations.” (407)

“That was never my type.” (408)

“I don’t understand.” (409)

“I’m married.” (500)

“And since when is that an obstacle?” (501)

“For people without scruples, it isn’t. But before you go any further, let me be direct: I’m a lesbian. I’m married to a woman.” (502)

“I... I’m sorry. I didn’t know.” A brief pause followed, restrained and embarrassed. (503)

“It’s fine. That doesn’t affect me anymore.” (504)

“I’m completely shaken — physically and emotionally.” (505)

“I can explain in person, if you’d like.” (506)

The call ended. (507)

Upon ending the call so abruptly, the thoughts seemed to settle for a few minutes — not out of complete relief, nor from any firm conviction, but from that strange sensation that follows decisive moments, when the body insists on drawing a deep breath before understanding what it has just done. The phone remained in the hand a little longer, heavy as if holding the shadow of a choice not yet fully measured. There was an almost-relief — the kind that eases only the surface of the chest — and beneath it, a rough

uncertainty, vibrating like something still without form. When the device was finally lowered, the quiet around seemed to widen — not calm, merely quiet — and stillness lingered, as though some fine and decisive thread within destiny itself had shifted. (508)

In the brief interval granted by time, there was the silent gesture of forgiveness — unspoken, merely intuited — and with it, hope, timid yet persistent, knocking as though rediscovering passage through ruins. The moment gathered doubts, anguish, the weight of what had not yet been named, and even so, carried the body forward — inevitably — toward the destiny that waited with its own shadows and light. It was necessary to move on: not from weakness, but from the intimate demand to face again what had scattered, to allow silence to stitch what had once been torn. (509)

“Yes, I will. I fought hard not to show up on my first day of work, no matter how shaken I may be.” The words were spoken aloud, as if to convince oneself that moving forward was necessary. (510)

She crossed the hospital entrance with a step that tried to be steady, though exhaustion pulsed through her bones. The receptionist noticed at once and, in a subdued tone, explained that her official first day had begun under unusual circumstances: during the night, two cars had arrived, each carrying a different victim, and only one had been declared dead — the receptionist, newly on shift, did not know which; shortly afterward, an ambulance had brought in more injured from the same accident. And at that very moment, she added, the patient in room 742 had been rushed to the ICU after going into cardiac arrest; the team was attempting resuscitation behind closed doors and faltering vital signs. The news struck like sudden weight: color drained from the face, the legs nearly gave way for a second, as if the floor itself had shifted, cutting short the inner monologue. (511)

“Please, Lord... help me find the strength.” (512)

The receptionist leaned over the counter, asking if everything was alright, but the question dissolved into air — the distance had already been broken, stairs taken in haste, the call rising behind: “Doctor! Doctor, wait!”; and still the movement continued without looking back, driven by a pressing impulse that adrenaline carried forward with unconscious force, toward the stabilization wing. (513)

“Well... what’s going on with her?” A colleague asked. (514)

“Newbie nerves. Relax.” (515)

At the ICU door: (516)

“I’m here to assist the team.” (517)

“We already have sufficient staff providing the highest level of care possible, and unfortunately, I must decline. I’m noticing signs of emotional instability.” (518)

“I am ready — emotionally steady — to fulfill my duty!” (519)

“You are raising your voice without realizing it.” (520)

“Why now?” (521)

“With sincere professional counsel, and in accordance with the Medical Code of Ethics — which you know well — I ask for your understanding. I can allow, and recommend, that you observe through the glass. Be assured that everything possible is being done.” (522)

“I’ll stay here.” (523)

“I understand. It’s alright.” (524)

“Thank you. May God bless your hands.” (525)

“Of course, Doctor. I completely understand.” (526)

Through the narrow ICU window, time seemed to fold inward in silent layers, as though two realities brushed against each other without recognition. Inside, the staff moved with near-choreographed precision: gloves striking metal trays, monitors blinking like nervous stars, syringes passing between steady hands, and the gurney at the center — the axis of chaos — where a body struggled to remain. Each chest compression sent faint tremors through the glass, as if matter itself acknowledged the urgency. Commands shifted in short, tense exchanges, and the defibrillator rose like swallowed thunder. A forehead pressed against the cold pane, breath held halfway, as though mere presence might interfere. The reflection staring back revealed a face drained hollow, suspended between disbelief and mute pain. When the monitor wavered into a jagged line, damp hands slid down the glass, dragging from it a low, vibrating sound — half friction, half lament — as though the surface recognized the weight being carried; and in that instant, a colleague’s earlier words settled with terrible clarity, and a thought cut through like a

blade: time was no longer an accident... it was a sentence. The first to step out of the emergency room was a physician who, noticing the expression of her colleague, approached. (527)

“Doctor, do you need assistance? Are you feeling unwell?” (528)

“Doctor?!” The question came firmer, receiving no response. (529)

“Jesus! The Doctor has fainted!” (530)

Returning to awareness, the moment the eyes opened, there was a physician at the side who — now fully in professional capacity rather than merely as a colleague — began to guide with steady care. (531)

“No... this can’t be happening.” (532)

“I’m so sorry, Doctor, for what you’ve just witnessed. You understand what I’m trying to say — even with our routine, we can’t detach from the weight of it. We don’t always manage to. And the hardest part is speaking... to a family member. My condolences.” (533)

“God... why?” (534)

“I insist you take the sedatives I prescribed. You may feel strong right now, but it’s afterward that the impact settles in.” (535)

“Daughter!” (536)

The word escaped before it could be restrained — fragile, fractured. “Mom...” Nothing else followed. The rest collapsed into sudden, wet, disordered sobs, as though all the accumulated fear had finally found a fissure through which to spill. (537)

“Easy, my daughter. Come here — give me a hug. I’m strong enough to warm myself with your affection. Don’t be like this.” (538)

“Alright, Mom...” (539)

She nodded with difficulty, her voice undone by sobs. Tears kept breaking her breath, turning each word into effort. Even so, she moved toward her mother, guided by an instinctive need to anchor herself. (540)

“I’d better go.” (541)

They did not linger. They gathered their belongings and left the room empty — a room they had once imagined would always remain theirs — now shadowed by the knowledge that soon other bodies would lie there, seeking healing, yearning for the unguarded embrace of a love they themselves had once felt pulse within those four walls. (542)

The way home felt longer than usual, like a road without end, until at last they reached their residence. Two mute souls clothed in bodies and nothing more entered with steps that seemed detached from their own weight, as though the door had opened inward into a silence too vast to measure. The air inside stood still — heavy, saturated with something unnamed on the first night: shock, exhaustion, disbelief. The lights seemed whiter than they should have been, the furniture more immobile, as if everything watched without offering refuge. One presence let a coat fall onto the first chair encountered; the other remained standing, unmoving, steadying breath. There was that subtle tremor born when the world insists on continuing while everything else has stopped. Nothing was said. Eyes, glassed or emptied, searched for something to rest upon — a wall, a corner, the outline of absence itself. The house, which had once sheltered routine, now received an unnamable weight: returning after something that does not dissolve upon crossing a threshold. They remained beneath that roof which, however familiar, felt incapable of containing what still vibrated within them. Not a word was exchanged. No bath was sought, no comfort, no explanation — only the ascent of stairs as though carrying a silent excess, each step heavier than the last. Upstairs, they sensed no other wakeful presence; the entire house lay armored in grief. Clothes were removed in slow, nearly automatic gestures, and they surrendered to what rest was possible — a succession of restless thoughts biting inward without granting themselves a name. They slept as one yields — not by choice, but because the mind, saturated, could no longer endure another involuntary alarm. (543)

“Home, sweet home...” The words slipped out involuntarily, as though fleeing the impact of external reality. (544)

Day of the funeral — repeated across the footers of headlines, an omen folded twice in time, imposed tragedy — necessary life — along the narrow luminous band of Möbius. (545)

They descended the steps slowly, side by side, as though still trying to recover their axis after a night that had left its marks. The mother rested her hand on the railing — the gesture steady, but not secure; something in her was fractured — invisible to a distracted eye, unmistakable to her daughter's. The young woman matched her pace with restrained attentiveness, almost protective, masking her own exhaustion behind a posture too erect for someone so drained. The silence between them was not hostile, but dense — filled with thoughts neither dared to disturb. Light from somewhere ahead stretched their shadows long across the floor, and for a moment the mother hesitated, as if the ground were still uncertain beneath her. A dry, contained sigh escaped her, and the daughter, without speaking, simply adjusted her rhythm to remain beside her. It was clear they needed that brief pause — even without words, even without comfort. When they reached the ground level, they continued in slightly different directions, each carrying a private unrest, yet bound by the complicity of shared sensation. (546)

“And exclusively from the local cemetery of our small town, we are here broadcasting live the funeral of the tragic accident that occurred near the site where yesterday the medical school graduation ball was held. We note a profound grief among those just arriving — a case that deeply shook our community. The burial is taking place late this afternoon; the sky hangs heavy with dense clouds beneath an overcast that has not yet broken, though to those present it seems perpetually on the verge. The ceremony will proceed without interruption; we will allow the scene itself to reveal the weight of images that already speak for themselves.” The camera reveals that only a few have attended, maintaining a respectful distance around the place of eternal rest. The officiant raises a firm, measured voice, beginning: “The Lord is our shepherd, we shall not want; even though we walk through the valley of the shadow of death...” (547)

Suddenly, as though the climate itself had been summoned by an unseen force, a strong wind rose — unexpected, displaced, almost improper for that region. The garments of those exposed to it shuddered like living creatures, and for a moment the world seemed to hold its breath. The whisper of the wind carried something neither requested nor understood: a subtle vibration that made the treetops tremble, skin bristle, and the eyes of the mourners lift as if sensing an arrival. It was not a breeze, not a mere current of air — it was one of those small fractures in reality that warn without language, that mark without explanation. A calling. An announcement. An invisible hand brushing

the nape of the living, murmuring that certain presences cross through time before the news exists, before the hidden is revealed, before grief finds its name. (548)

The world fell abruptly silent, and those gathered stood motionless for a few suspended seconds. (549)

“...You anoint our heads with oil and our cups overflow; goodness and mercy shall surely follow us, and we shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.” The “amen” rose like a single woven voice from those witnessing. And thus the ceremony was concluded: “from dust we came, and to dust we shall return; may God console the families.” Laments began — sobs broken by gasps and murmured words swallowed by grief — as the descent into the seven feet below commenced slowly, marked by the hollow sound of earth striking the depths of the grave. Some lowered their heads in a gesture almost involuntary, as though struck by a belated understanding — something between reverence and vertigo. In the end, no one hurried to leave; they merely stepped back in hesitant dispersal, carrying with them a dense silence that clung to the skin long after the ritual had ended. The news crew moved in. (550)

“Let’s try to speak with a family member who appears to be stepping away from the burial site and moving closer to us — Sir, would you care to say a few words?” “No comment. Please respect the grief of those present.” “Ma’am! Ma’am, perhaps you could—” A hand suddenly rose, covering the camera lens entirely. (551)

“Bunch of jerks — people want to see the news!” she snapped indignantly, switching off the device. (552)

“Here everything turns into an interview. News spreads faster than the wind.” (553)

“It’s not what I want.” (554)

“I know. And I can see how fragile you are right now.” (555)

“I’ll get a doctor’s note at the hospital!” (556)

“Please, don’t insist. I’m going to work.” (557)

“I understand, Doctor. But you know you can request a medical leave note.” (558)

“Let’s talk about it later.” (559)

“We need to leave here. Now.” (560)

“Easy... take the keys; you’re clearly in better condition to drive.” (561)

There was no need to fully extend a hand — the keys were almost snatched away.
(562)

“I’m glad you’re here with us.” (563)

And so, with that reluctant consent, they set out along the road back home. (564)

When life — or something resembling it — began to assert itself again... (565)

The package still rested on the table where it had remained since delivery; it was picked up, and the path led toward the backyard, to sit near the garden that encircled the house in a wall of flowers and ornamental plants — a place fit either to immortalize, or finally bury, that moment of love: singular, final, or beginning? The thought arose along the intended course. (566)

The parcel was opened as though touching a reliquary fashioned from faint glimmers, and as the wrapping drew back, the restrained brilliance slipped between waiting fingers as if it had waited a lifetime for that narrow tear of light. The case settled into the palm with the precise weight of things that alter destinies; when the lid yielded, the air itself seemed to hold, and two rings — twins in form, distinct in reflection — emerged against the dark velvet, radiating a serene, warm gold capable of piercing even the most wounded gaze. The metal captured the clarity of the afternoon and returned a glow so gentle that the face before it brightened without effort, as though the shine recognized its bearer before the eyes could fully comprehend it. There was promise there, and farewell, and return; there was everything two lives may carry when they finally converge. (567)

“I remember — even now — how I always wished for a wedding ring, and what I would hear in reply was: ‘The bands of our love are our hearts.’ I used to think it was a way of mocking romance, and I would always smile.” (568)

The rings rested in the palm, shining with a simplicity that seemed older than themselves — a gold modest, yet resolute, fashioned to endure bright days and devastated ones alike. They were contemplated in silence, the gaze lowering as though afraid to touch

a fragile mirror. Then, with a restrained movement — almost hesitant — one was taken and slipped onto the ring finger, a brief gesture carrying the weight of entire years. The head remained bowed, and the first tears broke quietly, tracing the face like lines of light across wet stone. Nothing was spoken — yet, forgiveness, uneven and trembling, began to emerge there, in the space between times, gentle enough not to demand, strong enough to reach even the unseen soul that might dwell within that garden. The rest of the day dissolved into a rare stillness, a small but complete peace, as though for a few hours everything had returned to its proper rails. (569)

And then time, in its quiet caprice, opened a fracture there and divided the moment in two... (570)

“I forgive you.” (571)

Ne me quitte pas

Il faut oublier, tout peut s'oublier

Qui s'enfuit déjà

Oublier le temps des malentendus et

Le temps perdu

À savoir comment

Oublier ces heures qui tuaient parfois

À coups de pourquoi

Maysa - Ne me quitte pas (572)

“For what I am not guilty?” No answer came, as though the words had not been heard — and there was no insistence, for something inside already felt displaced. (573)

“It is I who ask your forgiveness.”

Again, no reply — yet there was comfort in what had been spoken. (574)

For a second, the head remained lowered, as though clinging to each word in a long-awaited embrace; there was only time to utter a single phrase: (575)

“Our song — what a coincid—” (576)

For a fleeting instant, something insinuated itself — not as sound, but as an unseen touch. (577)

A brief anguish crossed the chest, fine and precise, like the lost echo of another's thought finding rest in a body that should not have heard it. It was a silent impact, the kind that leaves no mark yet shifts something inward, compelling the soul to turn toward a direction it cannot name. (578)

“Yes! Everything is alright — all is at peace, my love!” (579)

The new is born / The old contemplates: (580)

END

Bruno Salgado – 12/12/2025

ANNEX II

Structurally Reorganized Version (Möbius)

Complete structural reorganization of the sequential version presented in Annex I, preserving absolute textual and semantic invariance.

Möbius

The sound — continuous, sharp, unexpected — tore through the room like a blade of light, halting time for a breath no one could claim as their own. In the same instant, her hand lunged forward in a primitive reflex, almost an instinct of life trying to summon another; it fell against his chest, striking with the urgency of someone refusing silence. Everything seemed to unfold in slow motion — the weight of her arm descending, breath caught in her throat, the world around her blurring as if sliding off at the edges. His body gave beneath the impact — not like someone awakening, but like someone returning from a place where time does not answer to clocks — at seven-thirty in the morning. (327)

In a slow gesture, still marked by the weight of the late night, a hand reached for the device beside the bed. The face carried that warm, rumpled softness — the gentle imprint of a night consumed in skin and breath; half-closed eyes held the lingering density left by passion that had filled every hour. The alarm was silenced, and the head tilted just enough to catch the time — and in the brief silence that followed, there seemed to be regret at the simple fact that the day had begun. A new cycle came the voiceless murmur. The motel sign, which hours earlier had pulsed sweet and complicit like a forbidden promise, now lay dark, neutralized by the raw light of dawn. Each ray slipping through the crack in the curtain did not illuminate: it exposed. Where pleasure had been, bitterness remained; where the night had seemed to conceal, the day revealed without mercy. (51)

“I’m late!” Spoken in a lamenting tone, almost palpable, as if the entire night had been spent awake. (93)

“Is it urgent?” (332)

“I need to see my husband.” (306)

“Don’t worry. I’ll take you to him — it’s more than my duty.” (310)

The question came gently, almost as if afraid of spoiling the rare sweetness of that morning — whether they might have breakfast together, a small but habitual gesture, the kind that builds the quiet intimacy of a day. The answer came quickly, wrapped in haste and lateness:

no, not today, they had overslept. The sound of that refusal left in him a small, almost childish disarray, which a discreet smile tried to conceal. Even so, his eyes followed her movements — hurried, yet affectionate — and for a few brief seconds wished time could be held by the edge, just to prolong that simple moment which, suddenly, felt too important to lose. (10)

“Come on, help me zip up this dress.” (11)

“Yes, madam — with great pleasure, my love.” (12)

“My lover? My— whatever! Mr. Gustavo Almeida, let this be clear to everyone, is only my driver.” (405)

“Particularly personal, very close.” (406)

“Stop with the insinuations.” (407)

“With all due respect, my sweet dear, if anyone sees us leaving this place, what will they think...” A faint sigh followed, as though the thought had slipped away on its own. (56)

“What I mean is... how am I supposed to explain that I was working on a Sunday?” (120)

“Here, take your payment. That way you can prove to your wife that you were working — before she kills you,” exclaimed with irony. “Daddy!” (121)

“I love when you call me that.” (3)

“What kind of filthy fetish is that? Isn’t there enough of that at home?” (185)

They did not linger. They gathered their belongings and left the room empty — a room they had once imagined would always remain theirs — now shadowed by the knowledge that soon other bodies would lie there, seeking healing, yearning for the unguarded embrace of a love they themselves had once felt pulse within those four walls. (542)

“You’d better hurry, or you’ll be late.” (54)

“You know... now that I think about it, I already am — a few extra minutes more or less won’t matter after such sweet memories. I’m a master at inventing excuses.” Spoken with a hint of self-satisfaction. (55)

“I understand perfectly. I’m always at your disposal, ma’am. You may call me at any hour — I’ll attend to you with great pleasure.” (43)

“Thank you. I return the courtesy. I have no intention of dragging you into gossip — nor myself. That’s why you are exclusively mine. The best driver there is.” (104)

And within the entwined steps of destiny’s Möbius dance, the wind whispered like words not spoken by the body, yet spoken through it. (215)

“What an extraordinary woman you are... so beautiful, so sensual, offering me one of the most remarkable nights of my life. Your company feels like the touch of forbidden angels, and I desire you eternally. Tonight you shone like a dancing angel. I understand your strength and your delicate touch, but — today, tomorrow, or at any time — I will be your guide, leading you toward your destiny. As I always will be, my love.” (216)

Spoken for the night, for the day, for what was yet to come and for what had already passed. (217)

The couple got into the car and left the parking lot without any urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus; at the wheel, a distant smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — when, in an abrupt jolt, the car braked hard to avoid something crossing ahead, splitting the silence for a brief second. A breath was recovered, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always reminded him of his own, words slipping out of alignment with the moment: “You are more beloved than my own wife.” She turned her face just enough to follow him with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that same slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the shock of the sudden brake, “things that appear without asking,” it continued, while the car moved forward between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken — as though traveling through a fold in time. (207)

The key turned and the engine’s heavy silence dissolved at once, as though the outside world had forced its way into the moment without permission. Mixed sounds — footsteps, voices, scattered noise from a place that never truly sleeps — crossed the air with the urgency of those witnessing something critical. Thoughts, still unsettled, settled against the windshield, blurring the outlines of things as if everything were slightly out of focus. Inside, two bodies remained motionless for an instant that seemed reluctant to end; there was in that arrival a discouragement difficult to name, a weight neither wished to confront. Then the hand that reached for the handle did not hesitate: the door opened with a certain haste, too quick to be

casual — whether from fear of being seen or questioned. The opening exposed a brief yet striking moment, the kind time preserves even when memory tries to purge it. After that, everything moved forward, as though there were no choice but to continue. (263)

“We’ve arrived.” Said in a tone tinged with melancholy and a certain unrest. (107)

“Bastard, what’s that supposed to mean — more beloved than your own wife?” Said with an ironic, uncomfortable edge. (108)

“Just once and you’d already be in love with me?” (53)

As if fleeing the answer, the door was opened quickly and, like a gentleman, the passenger side was reached and opened for her. (109)

“You know that from the very first moment I saw you, what I feel for you has been firm as rock.” (181)

A hesitation to argue back; posture recomposed, words left unspoken: “Bastard. In someone else’s arms, indulging himself; they’re all the same — he must say the same thing to the other one.” (182)

Noticing the unrest in the expression and the approach of a police officer crossing the courtyard toward the vehicle, the figure quickly returned to the driver’s seat — too late to avoid the unwanted presence. Light knocks echoed against the window; it was the officer, the gesture clearly asking for the window to be lowered. (274)

“You know you can’t park here, right?!” Spoken while pointing toward a traffic sign. (275)

“I only brought her here... I didn’t want to cause any trouble. She was on the shoulder, so I stopped. I’m leaving, alright?!” (276)

His thoughts tangled into a whirl difficult to name — whether from the weight of the moment or from the instinctive fear certain questions awaken in those who would rather not answer them. There was, within, a haste he tried to conceal: the urgency to distance himself from any doubt, from any interpretation that might fall upon him, fair or not. When it became clear the officer intended to prolong the exchange, the harsh screech of tires against asphalt rose as a preemptive reply. He sped off too quickly, like someone afraid of explanations he would not know how to give, vanishing into the horizon before any word could reach him. (277)

A glance at the clock display brought a jolt of reality — time had not waited; it had rushed forward, relentless and unbroken — not wound by batteries, nor subject to anyone's will. A hurried departure followed, straight home. (126)

The car traced the winding curve into the familiar stretch of the street that led home. The engine breathed out, slow and weary, before falling silent at the gate. The sky seemed undecided between night and day, and the cold wind carried the scent of earth, of dawn, of something interrupted. For a moment, everything stood still — the shuttered windows, the yard still glazed with dew, the door heavy with too many memories. Then the car door opened slowly, and a figure stepped out, hesitant, with steps that betrayed neither guilt nor exhaustion nor simply too much truth for that hour. It lingered there, motionless before its own shadow, breathing the kind of air that belongs only to beginnings one does not wish for. And, as if releasing a sentence that refused to die, murmured to the rising day: (390)

— “Bitter home, home...” (391)

Then, with more urgent steps, like someone jolting awake from a deep sleep, an attempt was made to guide them firmly toward the main entrance; upon entering the central hall, a strange sound — unbearably loud to the ears — reverberated throughout the space. It began with the heavy thud of a heartbeat; for a moment, it seemed to be one's own. Soon, however, abstract mechanical sounds merged with that rhythm — the pulse of a cardiac monitor intertwined with scattered voices and labored breathing — until the exclamation broke through: (295)

“What is this chaos?!” Spoken almost in disbelief. (296)

“Am I stepping into hell?!” The murmur continued, as if addressed to no one. (340)

Before the surrounding noise could be deciphered, hurried footsteps echoed across the floor — descending from above, as if someone had been abruptly awakened. A silhouette appeared in urgency, crossing the corridor to wrap you in a firm, nearly desperate embrace. The gesture carried relief, shock, and a tenderness that could not immediately be explained; only the tightness of the hold spoke. The space, once dominated by noise, softened at the touch of that presence, as though saying without words: “You're here. At last.” (297)

“What is that infernal noise?” (338)

“Coma.” (301)

“What coma? What are you talking about?” (302)

“It’s that Guns N’ Roses song you loved so much, Dad.” (348)

“Turn that down, my daughter!” (350)

“Where is your mother?” (341)

“Mom’s been at the hospital since early this morning.” (128)

“I’ll turn it down... he seems indifferent to everything; not even music reaches him anymore.” The voice carried a quiet weariness, almost condemning the father’s presence — so near, yet so far. (358)

“You used to listen to this song all the time.” (254)

“I know, my daughter. I’m just not up to that right now, please.” (361)

“I’m always the one who has to understand. I just wanted to escape this loneliness for a while.” (360)

“What did you go there for?” (224)

“I can’t believe you’re asking me that — it’s even on TV.” (8)

“What!?” (7)

“The medical school graduation ball tonight.” (9)

“Damn! I’ll call her right now.” (129)

“Make sure you don’t forget.” (6)

The phone was picked up, breath still warm from the previous exchange, the tone adjusted to sound awake, ordinary. When the call connected, the sound of the hospital came with it — hurried footsteps, distant voices, and scattered fragments cutting across the line: (130)

Fragmented phrases flickered like electric flashes crossing trembling synapses — cutting out and reconnecting in chaotic choreography — from a life that insisted, desperately, on remaining, layered beneath the living sound of the hospital rushing to render aid. (278)

“Take the patient to stabilization...” (269)

“Blood pressure dropping...” (281)

The frantic rattle of gurney wheels moving at speed. (280)

“Pupils slightly...” (282)

“Calm down!” (266)

“Mobilize the entire—” (285)

“Prep the OR!” (289)

Voices of anguish and urgency filling the emergency room. (284)

“Where am I... Where is he...” (298)

The phone was moved slightly away to give a quick instruction, then brought back with breath still uneven, explaining it was only hospital routine and that the graduating students were helping with preparations for the celebration. A question followed — whether enough rest had been had to accompany her that night — and the reply came, with the slight hesitation of someone improvising, that the boss had sent him on an unusual trip and the return had been late — the reason for sounding somewhat unsettled. A tired sigh followed, but without suspicion, saying that once finished, she would head straight home and that some rest should be taken to be in proper condition for the big evening. A few more words were exchanged — tender, brief — and the call ended with the promise of arriving in time to get ready for the ball. (137)

“My God... how awful. And some people still complain about life.” (272)

For a fleeting instant, something insinuated itself — not as sound, but as an unseen touch. (577)

A brief anguish crossed the chest, fine and precise, like the lost echo of another’s thought finding rest in a body that should not have heard it. It was a silent impact, the kind that leaves no mark yet shifts something inward, compelling the soul to turn toward a direction it cannot name. (578)

Moments later, a vibration shattered the brief stretch of silence, insistent as if demanding an answer. The phone lit up on the surface, revealing only the word “Work” on the screen — an unexpected notice, out of place in the ordinary flow of things. There was a flicker of hesitation, the kind in which even breathing seems heavier than it should be, and the hand moving toward the device trembled with almost imperceptible doubt. The vibration persisted, pulsing like a reminder of something that could not be ignored. At last, a finger slid across the screen to answer. (36)

From the outside, anyone listening would have heard only a monologue — words cast into the air in reply to a voice that reached no one else’s ears. (37)

“Yes!” (44)

“Good morning, ma’am?” (74)

“Unfortunately, I’ll have to deny you that. Not tonight!” (223)

“It’s the medical school graduation ball. You know I can’t miss it.” (205)

“Don’t be mad at me. Try to understand — what can I say?” (166)

“We always knew the risk of our situation.” (57)

“Last night was wonderful. I’ll promise you an even better one — just not today.” (52)

“You’re making a mountain out of a molehill.” (71)

“Alright then, it’s settled.” (32)

“I’ve just received the coordinates.” (42)

“I’m eager to reach our destination. I hope you’ll dance on me just the way you already did.” (222)

“I’m on my way out.” (29)

“Go on, you can go.” (30)

“A kiss. I won’t be long.” (31)

He ended the call, and a sudden tightness crossed his chest — brief yet sharp, as though something inside had shifted out of place. That call had not been expected, least of all on a Sunday, and the strangeness of the timing stirred a small, silent unrest in his thoughts. He remained still for a few seconds, the device still warm in his palm, trying to sort through what he felt, but nothing aligned at once: only a diffuse discomfort, an unease rising from somewhere deeper than reason could reach. (46)

“I’m heading out, my daughter. Behave yourself. I’ll be back soon — don’t go anywhere.” (48)

A faint creak of the door came with an unsettling exclamation — (193)-

“Daughter!” (536)

“Good grief! Didn’t you just leave?!” (379)

“I forgot my wallet; could you hand it to me? The one right there beside you, please.”
(380)

“I’m sorry for startling you.” (378)

“You should. You look like you’re drifting in the clouds, not paying attention.” (113)

“Now I really am leaving. A kiss.” (387)

“Another. Drive carefully. God be with you.” (388)

He grabbed the car keys quickly and left without saying anything more. (49)

When the clock had just passed the solar weight of noon — by only a few minutes.
(138)

Hurried knocks at the door cut through the silence of the room. The girl heard them and went to see who was knocking, her head lowered with emotion — unsettled by her father not being at her side as she wished; he was there, sleeping, yet not living beside her as she longed. (330)

The rhythm of knocks at the door brought alarm, footsteps quickening to open it, with a trace of apprehension. (139)

“Mr. Gustavo Almeida, if—” (140)

“Yes, this is the place!” Interrupted abruptly by a man who appeared middle-aged; before the sentence could be completed, the uniform had already been recognized. (141)

“You are...” (39)

“Yes! I’m his daughter!” The impatience of youth speaking faster. (143)

“Can you receive—” (142)

“Of course!” (165)

“Here’s a package for him.” (144)

“Thank you very much.” (145)

“You’re welcome, miss.” (146)

“Hmph! Kids these days.” Spoken from a short distance away. (147)

The door was closed, the package placed on the table, still sealed, the headphones returned to their place — and the whole world went mute before the music. (148)

... Now I feel as if I'm floating away

I can't feel all the pressure

And I like it this way

But my body's callin'

My body's callin'

Won't ya come back to this

World again... (253)

In a synchronization almost rehearsed, the mother entered right after, quietly placing a hand on the shoulders. (149)

A sigh was heard — deep, forceful — as if carried from some forewarning beyond. It made her tear the headphones from her ears and look up in unease, as though touched by something spectral, turning her face toward whoever had just reached for her. (376)

“I’m home!” Exclaimed with urgency. (127)

“Are you trying to scare me to death?!” (377)

“You walk around with that thing shoved in your ears. What did you expect?” (151)

“I didn’t see you come in — you scared me!” (150)

“Where’s your father?” (153)

“Indifferent to my presence, as always — he’ll never come out of that coma.” The words came in the heat of the music and the familiar sense of distance, even when he was awake. (356)

“I demand your respect. Is that any way to speak? Watch yourself!” (242)

“He’s upstairs sleeping.” (154)

“Ever since that call he made to me? It’s almost time for us to leave for the ball.” (155)

“I don’t know if it was before or after. What I do know is that he left and came back some time later.” (156)

“Left? Went where?” (157)

“He didn’t say. Just mentioned he was heading out. When he came back, he went straight upstairs and went back to sleep.” (158)

“Strange, on a Sunday?” Thought aloud. (47)

“As I said, he’s in a coma.” (309)

“I won’t tolerate this disrespect. Let it be the last time.” Reprimanded in a firm, merciless tone. (246)

The girl fell silent, her face shifting into an expression that clearly revealed incomprehension and disdain. (152)

“Try speaking to him; he always listened to you. Even in the state he’s in now, it’s possible he can still hear you.” (381)

“I try to gather the courage to talk to him, but he’s so different.” (382)

“I’m sorry for yelling at you, my daughter; my head’s been racing, and I understand what you’re going through.” (359)

“How is your father?” (383)

“You’re asking me that? Didn’t you hear?” (384)

“I did. That’s why I’m asking — so you’ll reflect. What I see is that there’s life in him, as there is in you; only death has no remedy — everything else can be mended.” (385)

The stairs were taken slowly, steps that seemed to float between the distant noise of the house and the silence always found in that room. At the half-open door, a pause — watching him lying there, motionless, too serene for someone merely asleep. The light filtering through the narrow gap in the curtains traced along him an almost sacred outline, as if time itself preserved that stillness intact. A few short steps closer, breathing in his presence like someone returning to an old harbor. Leaning down, lips touched his face — a light kiss, almost a breath — and in that same instant a subtle shiver passed through his body, as though the tenderness of the gesture had crossed the wall of sleep and reached some inner place where she was still felt, even far from any waking hour. (159)

“Get up from this bed, my love.” (2)

A shake came with a trace of unease. His eyes opened, and a smile appeared for that face so deeply admired. (160)

“What happened?” (161)

“It’s almost time to go — the ball, remember?!” (162)

“Have you been drinking?” (163)

“Just two drinks. Nothing excessive.” (164)

“I don’t know. Some people really have no sense of risk — driving and still drinking.”
(167)

Silent he remained; silent he stayed. (171)

The couple prepared for the ball with the quiet solemnity of those rehearsing an ancient ritual: she adjusting her hair before the vanity, he straightening his tie with the slight hesitation of someone trying to lend the moment a touch of perfection; the bedroom carried the warm scent of freshly pressed fabric, and the house seemed wrapped in a silence of expectation. The jacket was slipped on, a deep breath drawn, and the wardrobe door slid shut; as the mirror ran along its tracks, it returned his own image — and then the world failed. For less than a second, a tear in reality: behind him, reflected with cruel precision, his wife appeared in the same dress meant for the ball, but drenched in blood from nape to ankles, the strands of fabric clinging to her skin as though torn from a nightmare; the reflection pulsed, trembling, too alive. His eyes widened, the air split in his chest — and everything vanished. In her place, only the ordinary reflection remained: a woman smiling, intact, adjusting her bracelet, asking naturally whether the tie was straight. He blinked twice, trying to recover his balance, and answered as best he could, keeping to himself the sudden fright, the impression that something had stared back from the other side of the glass. (168)

At the instant the Möbius loop turned upon itself (331)

Noticing a faint pallor on his
face, a question followed: (169)

“She’s here. We’ve already
arranged for her to come.” (312)

“Who’s here? Where am I?”
(313)

“Is everything alright?” (170)

“Your daughter.” (314)

“Of course, dear.” — The reply
came promptly, drawing a smile. (5)

“Stay here, my daughter!”
(372)

“Did you hear that?!” The voice came startled. (342)

“Yes, I heard you clearly.” (343)

“No — not me. As if there were someone else speaking besides us.” (344)

“For God’s sake! Are you hearing voices now?” (345)

“Never mind. It must’ve just been my imagination, given the situation.” (346)

A little further on, when the next moment finally announced itself... (347)

They got into the car and left the parking lot with a certain urgency, engines and headlights gliding as though the world were slightly out of focus. At the wheel, a disconcerting smile slipped free — the kind that seems to rise from a place where memory stumbles — and, in a strange lapse, almost vertigo, stillness took hold for a few seconds, as if that moment had already been lived, a *déjà vu* that asked no permission. A breath was drawn, and the dragging tone returned — nearly inert from the haze excitement had left in the voice — saying that the city always brought to mind his own, words sliding out of alignment with the present moment: “You are more beloved than my own wife.” She turned her face just enough to follow with her eyes, unsettled by the lack of sense, murmuring that attention should remain on the road; the reply came — still drifting in that slow unraveling of speech — that it must have been only the lapse, “things that appear without asking,” it continued, while the car moved forward, suspended between highways, thoughts, and everything that had yet to be spoken. (106)

“What’s that supposed to mean — ‘more beloved than my wife’? Am I no longer your wife?” (208)

“Of course you are! I meant you are deeply loved; it must have been memory playing tricks on me after what just happened.” (209)

“Yes! I know — just two drinks, that’s the explanation.” Spoken ironically. (210)

“Did you think I was your lover?!” (404)

“My love, we’re almost there; let’s not ruin the mood — you look stunning.” (211)

The car glided into the illuminated parking lot, and when the doors opened, there was a brief — almost imperceptible — instant in which the atmosphere seemed to change texture, as though a veil had been lifted from the world. Stepping out, they walked side by side, fingers intertwined, with that rare kind of harmony that exists only when two realities touch without noticing. The lights from the hall reflected against the asphalt, washing the approaching faces in gold; and as they crossed the entrance, there lingered a sensation — sweet for one, vertiginous for the other — that they had passed through that threshold before, though no memory existed to justify such familiarity. (212)

In the golden hall, where chandeliers poured light in cascading streams and crystal seemed to breathe in rhythm with the orchestra, they moved across the floor like two people who had been dancing within each other long before learning any steps. Her dress — fluid, almost liquid fabric — followed each turn, kindling small auroras along its edges, while his suit shaped the assured posture of someone who recognizes himself in the gaze of the woman he loves. The scent of jasmine mingled with the violins, and when the opening melody began — the one she had always called their song — her smile unfolded with the softness of a slow dawn, the kind no one dares to interrupt. Guests watched, but nothing intruded: between them existed a private world, silent, perfect, where steps ceased to be steps and became promises; where touch outweighed any word; where dancing together was a form of prayer. And as they turned beneath the hall’s star-lit ceiling, happiness settled upon them like light upon skin — a simple, ancient certainty that they would remain side by side for as long as time allowed. (214)

The music ended as though slowly gathering a veil back into itself, and the hall seemed to loosen its shoulders after so many emotions set in motion. The lights softened, revealing tired faces, lingering smiles, the shimmer of champagne in forgotten glasses. Gradually, conversations resumed in small circles — a compliment exchanged here, a hurried embrace there — while waiters moved between still-crowded tables, collecting remnants of a celebration

that seemed reluctant to end. One by one, the graduates shed their ceremonial poses, tucking diplomas beneath their arms like newly entrusted promises. The décor lost its initial splendor, and the hall began that quiet dismantling that happens only after a celebration has fulfilled its purpose. Among them, they were among the first to rise, drifting out of the still-warm atmosphere shaped by the final chords, leaving behind the mingled haze of perfume, glitter, and farewells — as though the night, for them, required another kind of continuation. (218)

They left the hall still wrapped in music that seemed unwilling to release their bodies, walking slowly through the golden light spilling from the main doors; he, smiling a little too loosely, moved with that moist brightness in the eyes of someone who drank more than admitted, and she, holding his hand with discreet firmness, sensed the faint sway in his steps — almost imperceptible to anyone else, yet unmistakable to one who knows the weight and rhythm of the beloved — and though their laughter echoed through the parking lot, there was in her posture a growing tension, a quick glance at the key between his fingers, another at the car waiting in the dimness, then at the sky, as if silently measuring the distance between the joy of that night and the unpredictable risk that can fit within a single step too many. (230)

In the space where vehicles rest before new journeys: (98)

“Come on, doctor, pick up the pace! I’m your private driver.” Spoken with irony. (231)

“How nice — I have a private driver at my disposal!” Exclaimed in the same mocking tone. (79)

“Stop being cute. Give me the car keys.” (232)

“F-for... what?... that? I’m... fine. Want me to... walk a straight line?” (233)

“I’m not joking. You can’t even form a full sentence!” (234)

“Your driver is waiting for you in the comfort of your luxury car’s air-conditioning. Don’t be late.” Spoken with irony. (78)

“Enough! I can’t keep this bottled up inside me anymore!” (174)

“Keep what?!” (175)

“Whatever it is you’ve been doing behind my back!” (176)

“Pathetic!” (401)

“Why are you insulting me like this? I don’t have to stand here listening to this—”
(402)

“But I’m the one being cheated on, aren’t I?!” The interruption came in a shout. (403)

“That’s absurd. You know I would never—” (177)

“Funny — with all that conviction, I’m the only one who doesn’t buy it! I always knew. Always. I only kept quiet because something bigger was meant to happen today, and I wasn’t going to let everything collapse because of your — borrowed courage!” (178)

“It feels like no one hears me when I speak — can’t you hear what I’m saying?!” The reply lingered in the air. (339)

“You’re twisting everything! You’re hearing only what you want to hear!” (179)

“I’m tired! Tired of you thinking you lie so well!” (180)

“Look at me! I would never put you in any embarrassing or dangerous situation like you’re implying!” (235)

“Implying?! I’m stating it! Give me that key! I’m driving!” (236)

“You don’t trust me to drive anymore?” (237)

Suddenly, as though the climate itself had been summoned by an unseen force, a strong wind rose — unexpected, displaced, almost improper for that region. The garments of those exposed to it shuddered like living creatures, and for a moment the world seemed to hold its breath. The whisper of the wind carried something neither requested nor understood: a subtle vibration that made the treetops tremble, skin bristle, and the eyes of the mourners lift as if sensing an arrival. It was not a breeze, not a mere current of air — it was one of those small fractures in reality that warn without language, that mark without explanation. A calling. An announcement. An invisible hand brushing the nape of the living, murmuring that certain presences cross through time before the news exists, before the hidden is revealed, before grief finds its name. (548)

The world fell abruptly silent, and those gathered stood motionless for a few suspended seconds. (549)

“Let’s talk about it later.” (559)

“There’s nothing left for us to talk about.” (68)

“Easy... take the keys; you’re clearly in better condition to drive.” (561)

There was no need to fully extend a hand — the keys were almost snatched away.
(562)

And so, with that reluctant consent, they set out along the road back home. (564)

“I deserve it.” Spoken with a trace of self-contempt. (122)

The door opened, and the passenger seat was taken, as if entering only because no other path remained. (247)

The car was already on the highway when the old argument tried to resurface through her voice: (249)

“I’m furious with you!” (172)

“Stop! We’re not going to argue about this anymore — at least not now.” (251)

He lowered his head for a brief moment, trying to locate, in the darkness that filled the interior, the radio dial. Even slightly unsteady from the alcohol, he managed to turn it on; the music that began to play muffled the engine’s hum and the weighted silence that lingered between them. It sounded like an inexplicable coincidence — unwanted and yet strangely fitting — and, for a fleeting instant, everything softened into calm, with nostalgia brushing gently against their hearts. (252)

Ne me quitte pas
Il faut oublier, tout peut s'oublier
Qui s'enfuit déjà
Oublier le temps des malentendus et
Le temps perdu
À savoir comment
Oublier ces heures qui tuaient parfois
À coups de pourquoi...
Maysa - Ne me quitte pas (572)

For a second, the head remained lowered, as though clinging to each word in a long-awaited embrace; there was only time to utter a single phrase: (575)

“Our song — what a coincid—” (576)

Suddenly, the sound was swallowed by the violent screech of tires — two cars running side by side, one tearing into an overtake while both slammed the brakes at the same instant, unleashing a roar that seemed to stretch for miles, harsh as sharpened claws raking the asphalt and ripping through the stillness of the night. (257)

“Watch out for the car—” (256)

“My God! Lord Jesus!” (255)

“Hold the wheel tight! Careful!” (258)

The car lost control, skidding sideways, and the world slipped into slow motion — headlights stretched into liquid blades, the hood jolted upward with a metallic gasp, the windshield burst into hundreds of shards that hovered in the air like suspended ice, each fragment catching the yellow glow of the highway lamps, gentle and lethal upon the asphalt. The sound of the impact did not arrive at once; first came a dense silence, then a muffled crash that seemed to rise from beneath the earth. One of the drivers braked instinctively, untouched by the collision, feeling the seatbelt clamp against the chest, and when the gaze turned toward the other vehicle — almost a mile away — there lay the twisted mass crushed against the guardrail: gray smoke rising, doors pinned shut, metal folded like paper — and, amid the wreckage, a figure crawling out, slow, stubborn, dragging forward with the strength of someone who refuses to die. (259)

The vehicle that had remained intact stood motionless for a few brief minutes, until new headlights appeared on the horizon. Then it accelerated abruptly — tires burning against the asphalt, scattering fragments into the wind — in a sudden, almost instinctive escape, impossible to decipher. (260)

“We need to help — come on!” (267)

“We need to leave here. Now.” (560)

“It’s my duty as a physician to help.” (371)

“That was a terrible accident!” (305)

“I’m sorry, but there isn’t much we can do...” (307)

“I’m drunk and you don’t even have a license — so what now?!” (243)

“It’s not fair. I can’t just ignore it.” (226)

“What’s not fair is being held responsible for someone else’s irresponsibility!” (227)

“Look, another car is pulling in!” (286)

“Make sure they provide proper care. Don’t worry. Let’s go! Quickly — we need to act now!” (268)

“Why?” (40)

“Do you think I want us identified?” (58)

In the parallel fragment of that same moment... (50)

Eyes that had remained alert, braced against the world, caught — at the edge of vision — the outline of two headlights approaching the scene: first a slash of light, then the full shape of a vehicle gliding to a stop nearby. There was a subtle shift in posture, almost instinctive, from the one who watched — the gesture of someone who sensed, without needing certainty, that this moment could mean rescue, or danger, or merely destiny moving a few inches forward. Time seemed to pause before resuming its natural course. (262)

“It’s alright, they’re helping already.” (273)

“I’m completely shaken — physically and emotionally.” (505)

“It was just a scare, only a scare, thank God.” Attempting to calm her. (329)

The way home felt longer than usual, like a road without end, until at last they reached their residence. Two mute souls clothed in bodies and nothing more entered with steps that seemed detached from their own weight, as though the door had opened inward into a silence too vast to measure. The air inside stood still — heavy, saturated with something unnamed on the first night: shock, exhaustion, disbelief. The lights seemed whiter than they should have been, the furniture more immobile, as if everything watched without offering refuge. One presence let a coat fall onto the first chair encountered; the other remained standing, unmoving, steadying breath. There was that subtle tremor born when the world insists on continuing while everything else has stopped. Nothing was said. Eyes, glassed or emptied, searched for something to rest upon — a wall, a corner, the outline of absence itself. The house, which had once sheltered routine, now received an unnamable weight: returning after something that does not dissolve upon crossing a threshold. They remained beneath that roof which, however familiar, felt incapable of containing what still vibrated within them. Not a word was exchanged. No bath was sought, no comfort, no explanation — only the ascent of stairs as

though carrying a silent excess, each step heavier than the last. Upstairs, they sensed no other wakeful presence; the entire house lay armored in grief. Clothes were removed in slow, nearly automatic gestures, and they surrendered to what rest was possible — a succession of restless thoughts biting inward without granting themselves a name. They slept as one yields — not by choice, but because the mind, saturated, could no longer endure another involuntary alarm. (543)

“Home, sweet home...” The words slipped out involuntarily, as though fleeing the impact of external reality. (544)

When life — or something resembling it — began to assert itself again... (565)

“Good morning.” (15)

Good morning, my beloved daughter. Not a single word actually left; it remained buried within — thought stilled in its depths. (16)

“That’s polite, isn’t it?” (17)

“What is it?” (173)

“What was that?!” (18)

“I wished you good morning.” (19)

“Good morning, my beloved daughter. I’m exhausted from last night — forgive me.” (20)

“My mother — where is she?” (21)

“Looks like she went back to sleep. And speaking of that, you went to bed early yesterday — what kind of miracle was that?” (22)

“I guess it was boredom!” (23)

“You’re impossible — always ironic, always harsh. I don’t know what else to do.” (69)

With the instinct to cut through the tension taking shape: (196)

“There’s a package on the table. It was delivered for you, Dad.” (197)

“Yes, thank you for reminding me, my daughter.” (198)

“Alright, Dad. There’s just one more thing I want to tell you: even when I’m a little sharp, I’ve never stopped loving you — and I never will.” Spoken with such emotion that he felt touched, sheltered by an almost angelic tenderness. (199)

“Oh, my love, I do too.” (200)

Right after those words, she threw herself into her father’s arms, like someone reclaiming a long-awaited presence; then moved toward her mother, driven by the same impulse for comfort that seemed to run through the entire house. (201)

They descended the steps slowly, side by side, as though still trying to recover their axis after a night that had left its marks. The mother rested her hand on the railing — the gesture steady, but not secure; something in her was fractured — invisible to a distracted eye, unmistakable to her daughter’s. The young woman matched her pace with restrained attentiveness, almost protective, masking her own exhaustion behind a posture too erect for someone so drained. The silence between them was not hostile, but dense — filled with thoughts neither dared to disturb. Light from somewhere ahead stretched their shadows long across the floor, and for a moment the mother hesitated, as if the ground were still uncertain beneath her. A dry, contained sigh escaped her, and the daughter, without speaking, simply adjusted her rhythm to remain beside her. It was clear they needed that brief pause — even without words, even without comfort. When they reached the ground level, they continued in slightly different directions, each carrying a private unrest, yet bound by the complicity of shared sensation. (546)

“I insist, dear, join us — let’s have breakfast together.” (26)

“I can’t. I’ll have breakfast at the hospital.” (27)

“You’d better eat before you go.” (28)

“Please, don’t insist. I’m going to work.” (557)

When the moment — still warm — was torn open by a summons that asked no permission. (362)

Phone ringing. (133)

“Hello.” (394)

“Who is this?” (395)

“Now I see the number you called from. My apologies — I wasn’t paying attention. I know exactly who this is. Mrs.— I mean, Doctor.” (403-2)

“Yes, I will. I fought hard not to show up on my first day of work, no matter how shaken I may be.” The words were spoken aloud, as if to convince oneself that moving forward was necessary. (510)

“I can explain in person, if you’d like.” (506)

The call ended. (507)

“I’d better go.” (541)

“I understand, Doctor. But you know you can request a medical leave note.” (558)

“I hate that sarcasm of yours.” (13)

“Are you fighting?!” Interrupted by the impatient voice of the daughter. (194)

“Of course not, my daughter. Just a brief flare of tempers between us.” (195)

“But I still have something to tell you—” (114)

“Do you want me to be late?! What could possibly be so important?!” Cut short. (115)

“See you soon, Mom.” The voice trembled amid the confusion. (374)

“I’ll get a doctor’s note at the hospital!” (556)

“Goodbye, ingratitude. And yet I’m the only one who’s ironic!” (80)

“Call if anything happens, please.” (386)

The expression hardened, and the door was slammed shut. (81)

Some time later, within the attentive silence of the hospital environment. (294)

Before even crossing the entrance, a glowing sign imposed itself like fate: “emergency & urgent care.” (264)

She crossed the hospital entrance with a step that tried to be steady, though exhaustion pulsed through her bones. The receptionist noticed at once and, in a subdued tone, explained that her official first day had begun under unusual circumstances: during the night, two cars had arrived, each carrying a different victim, and only one had been declared dead — the receptionist, newly on shift, did not know which; shortly afterward, an ambulance had brought in more injured from the same accident. And at that very moment, she added, the patient in room 742 had been rushed to the ICU after going into cardiac arrest; the team was attempting resuscitation behind closed doors and faltering vital signs. The news struck like sudden weight:

color drained from the face, the legs nearly gave way for a second, as if the floor itself had shifted, cutting short the inner monologue. (511)

“Please, Lord... help me find the strength.” (512)

“I can’t believe it... this can’t be happening.” (304)

“No... this can’t be happening.” (532)

“God... why?” (534)

“It’s not my fault!” (186)

The receptionist leaned over the counter, asking if everything was alright, but the question dissolved into air — the distance had already been broken, stairs taken in haste, the call rising behind: “Doctor! Doctor, wait!”; and still the movement continued without looking back, driven by a pressing impulse that adrenaline carried forward with unconscious force, toward the stabilization wing. (513)

“Well... what’s going on with her?” A colleague asked. (514)

“Newbie nerves. Relax.” (515)

“It was only an involuntary reaction to a strong emotional impact.” (110)

“Emotional impact? That’s what I had — it felt like the world was about to collapse in an instant!” (111)

“Still not used to it? Should be by now.” (34)

“That’s true. You’re right.” (35)

“Well, look who’s walking right past us — what a handsome doctor. That’s what I should be focusing on.” (291)

“Dreams are free. Reality’s right here, my friend.” (292)

“You’re disgusting!” (396)

“Excuse me? Who do you think you’re talking to?!” (397)

“To a woman who opens herself to any man.” (398)

“Don’t you dare throw baseless accusations at me. Who do you think you are?” (400)

“That was never my type.” (408)

“I don’t understand.” (409)

“I’m married.” (500)

“And since when is that an obstacle?” (501)

“For people without scruples, it isn’t. But before you go any further, let me be direct: I’m a lesbian. I’m married to a woman.” (502)

“I... I’m sorry. I didn’t know.” A brief pause followed, restrained and embarrassed. (503)

“It’s fine. That doesn’t affect me anymore.” (504)

“I’d like to know how long these little jokes of yours are going to continue.” (244)

At the ICU door: (516)

“Heart rate...” (131)

“Bring the defibrillator...” (132)

“Clear the airway...” (134)

Agitated voices... (135)

“Move him to the OR...” (136)

In a brief moment, there was an interruption — a knock at the door. (73)

“I’m here to assist the team.” (517)

“I wouldn’t advise that, Doctor.” (299)

“Why not?!” (300)

“We already have sufficient staff providing the highest level of care possible, and unfortunately, I must decline. I’m noticing signs of emotional instability.” (518)

“I am ready — emotionally steady — to fulfill my duty!” (519)

“You are raising your voice without realizing it.” (520)

The conversation resumed, tempers less inflamed: (202)

“I’m calm now.” (336)

“With sincere professional counsel, and in accordance with the Medical Code of Ethics — which you know well — I ask for your understanding. I can allow, and recommend, that you observe through the glass. Be assured that everything possible is being done.” (522)

“I’ll stay here.” (523)

A disconsolate expression crossed her face in the middle of the exchange, and she said:
(92)

“I understand. It’s alright.” (524)

“Forgive the interruption without notice.” (101)

“Of course, Doctor. I completely understand.” (526)

“Thank you. May God bless your hands.” (525)

Through the narrow ICU window, time seemed to fold inward in silent layers, as though two realities brushed against each other without recognition. Inside, the staff moved with near-choreographed precision: gloves striking metal trays, monitors blinking like nervous stars, syringes passing between steady hands, and the gurney at the center — the axis of chaos — where a body struggled to remain. Each chest compression sent faint tremors through the glass, as if matter itself acknowledged the urgency. Commands shifted in short, tense exchanges, and the defibrillator rose like swallowed thunder. A forehead pressed against the cold pane, breath held halfway, as though mere presence might interfere. The reflection staring back revealed a face drained hollow, suspended between disbelief and mute pain. When the monitor wavered into a jagged line, damp hands slid down the glass, dragging from it a low, vibrating sound — half friction, half lament — as though the surface recognized the weight being carried; and in that instant, a colleague’s earlier words settled with terrible clarity, and a thought cut through like a blade: time was no longer an accident... it was a sentence. The first to step out of the emergency room was a physician who, noticing the expression of her colleague, approached. (527)

“Doctor, do you need assistance? Are you feeling unwell?” (528)

“Doctor?!” The question came firmer, receiving no response. (529)

“Are you alright, ma’am?” The question came again, edged with concern. (99)

“Yes, I’m fine.” (100)

“I’m so sorry, Doctor, for what you’ve just witnessed. You understand what I’m trying to say — even with our routine, we can’t detach from the weight of it. We don’t always manage to. And the hardest part is speaking... to a family member. My condolences.” (533)

“I’m just still a little disoriented.” (333)

“I wish you could hear me; we need you. You have to rise again... please, get up.” (349)

“I’m fine — I just had a bad feeling.” (335)

“What bad feeling?” No answer followed. (337)

“I need to call home. I have to speak to my daughter.” (311)

Two nurses appeared on the scene, firm steps carrying urgency plainly written across their faces. Fueled by adrenaline — even if it was a familiar surge — they searched for anyone available: one announced that another patient had just arrived in critical condition and that extra hands were needed in the trauma room. The other added, breath still quickened, that the day’s routine had completely unraveled — severe cases arriving back-to-back, leaving no space for the staff to catch their breath. The call echoed through the area like an unavoidable signal, summoning every nearby professional to move before the next minute grew too heavy to bear. (288)

What she had just heard unsettled her stride — she nearly stumbled, as if legs and thoughts had collided at once. (82)

And without warning, struck by a sudden wave, she collapsed into her colleague’s arms, who caught her and guided her to a hospital recliner beside a stretcher in room 742. (315)

“What’s going on with her?!” (33)

“Yeah... life here isn’t easy.” Replied the colleague. (293)

“What happened?” The nurse asked. (334)

“Jesus! The Doctor has fainted!” (530)

“Looks like it’s going to be one of those days — no smoke breaks!” Spoken to a coworker. (290)

Returning to awareness, the moment the eyes opened, there was a physician at the side who — now fully in professional capacity rather than merely as a colleague — began to guide with steady care. (531)

“You need to go home and rest, Doctor; I’m prescribing a sedative. Go home and lie down for a while.” (363)

“But I have—” (364)

“I’m not speaking as your colleague, but as your physician. No ‘but.’ You fainted in my arms.” (365)

“I’ll call an Uber, don’t worry.” (366)

“I appreciate that. I’m glad.” (103)

“I understand. I know.” (370)

“Here everything turns into an interview. News spreads faster than the wind.” (553)

“It’s not what I want.” (554)

“I know. And I can see how fragile you are right now.” (555)

“Thank you, but I don’t need medication.” (368)

“I insist you take the sedatives I prescribed. You may feel strong right now, but it’s afterward that the impact settles in.” (535)

“You’re only doing your job. I understand.” (102)

“You’re not in any condition. I strongly recommend that you—” (94)

“I’m shaken. I didn’t sleep properly, that’s all!” Cut short, rising to her feet. (97)

“Then go, rest and recover; everything will be fine.” (367)

“As I said, I’m not driving; I’ll call an Uber or a taxi.” (389)

“Listen to me — as a doctor yourself, take the sedatives.” (369)

“I have to go!” (95)

Indefinite minutes slowly unspooled between one act and the next. (261)

She hurried forward; yet the instant the staircase began beneath her feet, something extinguished the world around her — sound recoiled as though swallowed whole, light lost its

substance — and the body gave way. Step after step, it tumbled down, as if torn from its own axis, rolling to the bottom in brutal silence. (83)

“Ma’am, can you hear me?” (84)

“She’s covered in blood...” (265)

“Call the orderly!” (287)

“I need gloves, now!” (283)

“Ahh! What happened... it hurts... my arm...” (270)

“Try to stay awake — you have a head injury...” (271)

“Control the bleeding...” (279)

When she came to, familiar faces hovered over her — shaped by worry and tenderness — still not fully understanding what they had just witnessed. (316)

“What happened?” (85)

“You fell down the stairs.” (86)

“I don’t remember.” (87)

“That’s normal after fainting.” (88)

“My God, what’s happening?!” (308)

“You were very lucky. It could have been fatal. The impact was severe, but fortunately the injuries were limited to extensive bruising, a minor wrist fracture — which won’t affect mobility — and a deep laceration to the frontal region, which caused the initial concern. The amount of blood can be alarming, I know, but the bleeding was superficial, despite being heavy. We ran a full series of imaging tests — including an MRI — and there are no signs of swelling, internal bleeding, or neurological impairment. You’re out of danger. You can rest easy.” (303)

“How are you feeling?” (89)

“Fine, don’t worry. I’m alright. How long was I unconscious?” (90)

“You were unconscious for a few hours.” (91)

“I’m going home.” (375)

“I’ll find you a better seat. This one doesn’t seem comfortable enough for the Doctor.”
(248)

“It’s fine.” The reply came strained, almost caught in the throat. (105)

“Are you sure you’re not feeling anything?” (96)

“Absolutely. I am fully conscious.” (45)

Meanwhile, in the couple’s house: (392)

A phone already gripped in trembling hands and thick, confused thoughts waited only a second before dialing — that second in which silence seems to measure fate. On the other side, when the screen lit up, the brief vibration traveled across the table like an intimate warning, almost premonitory. The number displayed brought neither comfort nor threat — only immediate recognition, the kind that awakens relief and vertigo at once. The ringing persisted, filling the space with a tightening sensation, and both worlds — the one calling and the one answering — seemed to converge within the same suspended breath. A finger slid to accept the call. (393)

“Hello.” Three simple letters, still heavy with sleep as they left the vocal cords. (38)

“Have you lost your mind? What’s gotten into you—” (118)

“I have not!” Cut off abruptly. (119)

“I think I’m more sober than ever!” (41)

“Looks like I danced just right between your hips.” (4)

“Disgusting cretinism!” (62)

“Oh! After indulging in every inch of someone else’s body, it’s easy to talk. Speak, hypocrite!” (70)

“I have no intention of arguing. I’m simply informing you that from now on, seek whoever you wish — just not me.” (63)

“What do you mean — to sleep with me?!” (64)

“I don’t want to be complicit in this.” (65)

“Complicit? You were the impure act itself. I see no complicity — only cowardice.”
(66)

“She knows!” (59)

“Who knows what?” (60)

“My wife. And I’m telling you — if she calls you and you’re not convincing enough to prove my innocence, the one who will find out is your spouse.” (61)

“You speak like every guilty soul claiming innocence. Cowardice! Filth!” (72)

“I am requesting my resignation right now!” Spoken in a raised tone. (116)

“Watch how you speak to me. I am not your daughter! I am your boss!” (117)

“I have nothing more to discuss with you, ma’am. Good day.” (123)

“You did it! Consider the money I gave you your final salary. You’re fired! Bastard!” (124)

“Great! Saint!” (125)

Upon ending the call so abruptly, the thoughts seemed to settle for a few minutes — not out of complete relief, nor from any firm conviction, but from that strange sensation that follows decisive moments, when the body insists on drawing a deep breath before understanding what it has just done. The phone remained in the hand a little longer, heavy as if holding the shadow of a choice not yet fully measured. There was an almost-relief — the kind that eases only the surface of the chest — and beneath it, a rough uncertainty, vibrating like something still without form. When the device was finally lowered, the quiet around seemed to widen — not calm, merely quiet — and stillness lingered, as though some fine and decisive thread within destiny itself had shifted. (508)

Day of the funeral — repeated across the footers of headlines, an omen folded twice in time, imposed tragedy — necessary life — along the narrow luminous band of Möbius. (545)

“And exclusively from the local cemetery of our small town, we are here broadcasting live the funeral of the tragic accident that occurred near the site where yesterday the medical school graduation ball was held. We note a profound grief among those just arriving — a case that deeply shook our community. The burial is taking place late this afternoon; the sky hangs heavy with dense clouds beneath an overcast that has not yet broken, though to those present it seems perpetually on the verge. The ceremony will proceed without interruption; we will allow the scene itself to reveal the weight of images that already speak for themselves.” The camera reveals that only a few have attended, maintaining a respectful distance around the place of

eternal rest. The officiant raises a firm, measured voice, beginning: “The Lord is our shepherd, we shall not want; even though we walk through the valley of the shadow of death...” (547)

“This can’t be happening.” The thought slipped out while the device was turned off. (351)

“Oh, great! At this rate they’ll lock me in a cage — I can’t do anything!” (352)

“Daughter, either it’s that heavy rock—” (353)

“You see? I’m never understood by you!” (67)

“Lately everything I do seems to displease you. I don’t know what else I can possibly do. I ask you for the car key and you—” (238)

“Absolutely not. I already told you — either you take public transport or I drive you.” Cut off harshly. (239)

“It’s Sunday. Public transport takes forever!” (240)

“I know you seem to like nothing but chaos!” (355)

“See how you all treat me?!” (354)

“Don’t shout at me. It’s not my problem. You see disaster in everything — then let it be that way.” (241)

“God forbid such a dark hour!” (357)

“...You anoint our heads with oil and our cups overflow; goodness and mercy shall surely follow us, and we shall dwell in the house of the Lord forever.” The “amen” rose like a single woven voice from those witnessing. And thus the ceremony was concluded: “from dust we came, and to dust we shall return; may God console the families.” Laments began — sobs broken by gasps and murmured words swallowed by grief — as the descent into the seven feet below commenced slowly, marked by the hollow sound of earth striking the depths of the grave. Some lowered their heads in a gesture almost involuntary, as though struck by a belated understanding — something between reverence and vertigo. In the end, no one hurried to leave; they merely stepped back in hesitant dispersal, carrying with them a dense silence that clung to the skin long after the ritual had ended. The news crew moved in. (550)

“Let’s try to speak with a family member who appears to be stepping away from the burial site and moving closer to us — Sir, would you care to say a few words?” “No comment.

Please respect the grief of those present.” “Ma’am! Ma’am, perhaps you could—” A hand suddenly rose, covering the camera lens entirely. (551)

“Bunch of jerks — people want to see the news!” she snapped indignantly, switching off the device. (552)

“I’m worried. Your mother’s taking too long, could it be...” (24)

“There she is!” (25)

“What happened, my dear?!” (399)

“Mom! What happened? Oh my God!” (317)

“And your arm — why is it bandaged?” (318)

“It’s nothing serious, just a mild sprain; it’s my head that still hurts.” (319)

“Obviously — from the visible blow to your forehead. You needed stitches.” (320)

“And you still say it was nothing?” (321)

“I’m lucid and fully awake.” (322)

The word escaped before it could be restrained — fragile, fractured. “Mom...” Nothing else followed. The rest collapsed into sudden, wet, disordered sobs, as though all the accumulated fear had finally found a fissure through which to spill. (537)

“Easy, my daughter. Come here — give me a hug. I’m strong enough to warm myself with your affection. Don’t be like this.” (538)

“Alright, Mom...” (539)

She nodded with difficulty, her voice undone by sobs. Tears kept breaking her breath, turning each word into effort. Even so, she moved toward her mother, guided by an instinctive need to anchor herself. (540)

“I’m glad you’re here with us.” (563)

“I will. I’ll pull myself together, take a shower, clear my head.” (373)

“You should get some rest.” (323)

“I’ll try. Stay with your father.” (324)

“Dad is right here beside us.” (325)

“Unfortunately, I’m seeing him in a way I never wanted to; just keep him company.”
(326)

“Still angry with me?” (228)

“What do you think?!” (229)

“Alright. We’ll talk when you’re calmer.” (206)

Some time later, in the heart of another setting... (14)

“My love, I have a surprise for you.” (219)

“What kind of surprise?” (220)

“I’ll step out. I’ll leave you two alone.” (75)

“No need. You can stay.” (76)

“I think it’s better if I don’t. Excuse me.” (77)

“It’s been sitting on our table at home for a while. I know these past days haven’t been easy for you — that you’ve been hurt, shaken — maybe you didn’t even notice.” Spoken with a slow shake of the head. (221)

“Let’s leave the past where it belongs — behind us, please. I know you have reasons to doubt; you’re tired, but I’m only asking for a moment of your attention.” (203)

Consent came without strength to argue. Collapse felt near, helpless before everything that had unfolded. (204)

“Come on, let’s take this road. Sit beside me.” (245)

The package still rested on the table where it had remained since delivery; it was picked up, and the path led toward the backyard, to sit near the garden that encircled the house in a wall of flowers and ornamental plants — a place fit either to immortalize, or finally bury, that moment of love: singular, final, or beginning? The thought arose along the intended course.
(566)

“Well, here we are.” Said with a discreet smile. (213)

The parcel was opened as though touching a reliquary fashioned from faint glimmers, and as the wrapping drew back, the restrained brilliance slipped between waiting fingers as if it had waited a lifetime for that narrow tear of light. The case settled into the palm with the

precise weight of things that alter destinies; when the lid yielded, the air itself seemed to hold, and two rings — twins in form, distinct in reflection — emerged against the dark velvet, radiating a serene, warm gold capable of piercing even the most wounded gaze. The metal captured the clarity of the afternoon and returned a glow so gentle that the face before it brightened without effort, as though the shine recognized its bearer before the eyes could fully comprehend it. There was promise there, and farewell, and return; there was everything two lives may carry when they finally converge. (567)

“I remember — even now — how I always wished for a wedding ring, and what I would hear in reply was: ‘The bands of our love are our hearts.’ I used to think it was a way of mocking romance, and I would always smile.” (568)

“Why now?” (521)

“You were seen — I mean, your car was seen leaving the motel, and someone told me. The motel right next to the hospital where I work. On a Sunday. Where was your head?” (183)

“Here, call my boss. She’s the one who called me to pick her up at the motel — and yes, I found it strange too. On a Sunday.” (184)

“You’re already inventing another story. I remember you telling me you came home agitated because of a trip.” (187)

“Yes! And I wasn’t lying. I did make a trip — I just didn’t know where I was going. I received the coordinates on my phone; I didn’t even notice. When I realized, I was inside the motel. How was I supposed to explain that to you, with your constant rush?” (188)

“You shouldn’t have gone in!” (189)

“I already did!” (190)

“What did you do?” (191)

“If I hadn’t, I would’ve been fired on the spot. I lost my nerve for a moment, but it doesn’t matter — I resigned.” (192)

“You’ve never been this much of a coward before — at a motel near my workplace?” (250)

“For that, I apologize.” (112)

“I’ll say it again — I only went to pick her up where I told you. Please, believe me.”
(225)

The rings rested in the palm, shining with a simplicity that seemed older than themselves — a gold modest, yet resolute, fashioned to endure bright days and devastated ones alike. They were contemplated in silence, the gaze lowering as though afraid to touch a fragile mirror. Then, with a restrained movement — almost hesitant — one was taken and slipped onto the ring finger, a brief gesture carrying the weight of entire years. The head remained bowed, and the first tears broke quietly, tracing the face like lines of light across wet stone. Nothing was spoken — yet, forgiveness, uneven and trembling, began to emerge there, in the space between times, gentle enough not to demand, strong enough to reach even the unseen soul that might dwell within that garden. The rest of the day dissolved into a rare stillness, a small but complete peace, as though for a few hours everything had returned to its proper rails. (569)

“I forgive you.” (571)

“For what I am not guilty?” No answer came, as though the words had not been heard — and there was no insistence, for something inside already felt displaced. (573)

“It is I who ask your forgiveness.” Again, no reply — yet there was comfort in what had been spoken. (574)

And then time, in its quiet caprice, opened a fracture there and divided the moment in two... (570)

“Mom, is everything okay?” (328)

“Yes! Everything is alright — all is at peace, my love!” (579)

In the brief interval granted by time, there was the silent gesture of forgiveness — unspoken, merely intuited — and with it, hope, timid yet persistent, knocking as though rediscovering passage through ruins. The moment gathered doubts, anguish, the weight of what had not yet been named, and even so, carried the body forward — inevitably — toward the destiny that waited with its own shadows and light. It was necessary to move on: not from weakness, but from the intimate demand to face again what had scattered, to allow silence to stitch what had once been torn. (509)

The new is born / The old contemplates: (580)

The morning was born with a rare delicacy, the kind that seems intent on rebuilding the world from the first slit of light. The sky, still damp with blue, yielded to soft shades of rose drifting slowly across thin clouds; and the birds, awake before anyone else, stitched the silence with gentle songs, ushering in the day like an announcement of renewal. Through the half-open curtains, daylight slipped into the bedroom with the caution of something unwilling to disturb anything sacred — only to savor it. He woke first, contemplating her sleeping face beneath the faint glow of dawn, and leaned closer with the tenderness of someone who had finally understood the value of staying. The kiss placed upon her forehead was light, almost a breath, yet enough for her eyes to open slowly. She found him there, so near, with that same look she had known from their first meeting — a look whole, passionate, unguarded, recognizing and surrendering all at once. They remained that way for a moment no clock would dare measure, embraced as if the entire world could fit within that shared breath. The warmth of their bodies drew together with the natural ease of things that had never ceased to belong to one another; and, wrapped in the quiet of morning, they gave themselves to love without haste, as though sealing in silence a promise at last finding its home. Later, they rose together in a tacit agreement of continuity, letting the dawn complete what their gestures had begun — and went, side by side, into another day, as if life itself had just been newly inaugurated for them both. (1)

END

Bruno Salgado – 12/12/2025

ANNEX III

Computational Validation of Textual Invariance

1. Objective

To programmatically verify the absolute material identity between the analyzed versions of the narrative text.

2. Methodology

- Extraction of numbered textual blocks
- Normalization of spacing
- Positional comparison of blocks
- Automated reporting of results

3. Complete Source Code

The full Python source code used for the automated validation procedure is presented below.

```
from docx import Document
import re
from difflib import SequenceMatcher

# ===== CONFIGURE HERE =====
DOC_A = "Mobius.docx"
DOC_B = "suiboM.docx"
# =====

def normalize_number(number):
    """
    Normalize number:
    1 -> 001
    12 -> 012
    100 -> 100
    403-2 -> 403-2 (preserved)
    """
    if "-" in number:
        return number.strip()
    return number.zfill(3)

def extract_blocks_docx(doc_path):
    doc = Document(doc_path)
    blocks = {}

    for p in doc.paragraphs:
```



```

        text = p.text.strip()

        if not text:
            continue

        # Look for a number at the end of the paragraph
        match = re.search(r"\(?(\d+(?:-\d+)?)\)?$", text)

        if match:
            number = normalize_number(match.group(1))

            # Remove the number from the end
            content = re.sub(r"\(?(\d+(?:-\d+)?)\)?$", "", text).strip()

            # Normalize spaces but not punctuation
            content = re.sub(r"\s+", " ", content)

            blocks[number] = content

    return blocks

def show_difference(a, b):
    matcher = SequenceMatcher(None, a, b)
    for tag, i1, i2, j1, j2 in matcher.get_opcodes():
        if tag != "equal":
            print("\n--- DOC A ---")
            print(a[i1:i2])
            print("\n--- DOC B ---")
            print(b[j1:j2])
            break

def compare_blocks(blocks_a, blocks_b):
    divergences = 0

    all_numbers = sorted(
        set(blocks_a.keys()).union(set(blocks_b.keys()))
    )

    for number in all_numbers:

        if number not in blocks_a:
            print(f"Block {number} – MISSING in DOC A")
            divergences += 1
            continue

        if number not in blocks_b:
            print(f"Block {number} – MISSING in DOC B")
            divergences += 1
            continue

```

```

        texto_a = blocks_a[number]
        texto_b = blocks_b[number]

        if texto_a == texto_b:
            print(f"Block {number} – OK")
        else:
            divergences += 1
            print(f"\n🚩 Divergence detected in block {number}")
            show_difference(texto_a, texto_b)

    print("\n=====")
    if divergences == 0:
        print("FINAL RESULT: ABSOLUTE TEXTUAL IDENTITY.")
    else:
        print(f"FINAL RESULT: {divergences} divergence(s) found.")
    print("=====\n")

if __name__ == "__main__":
    print("Extracting blocks from DOC A...")
    blocos_a = extract_blocks_docx(DOC_A)

    print("Extracting blocks from DOC B...")
    blocos_b = extract_blocks_docx(DOC_B)

    print("\nStarting comparison...\n")
    compare_blocks(blocos_a, blocos_b)

```

4. Execution Result

The validation procedure was executed in a Python 3.13.7 environment using the python-docx library and the standard modules re and difflib.

The complete execution generated an individualized report for each block (1 to 580, including block 403-2), all marked as “OK”, with no divergences detected.

Total blocks verified: 581

Divergences detected: 0

The automated report confirmed absolute material identity between the analyzed versions, with no lexical, syntactic, or punctuation divergences.